

German, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

This book teaches German one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero, whose only shared language is English. The method is the same as its companion volumes — one word per lesson, gone deep — but the etymology flows through a different channel. Spanish and French are Latin’s children; *German is English’s sibling*. Both are Germanic languages, so German words are most often *direct cousins* of English words, with no Latin middleman: *gut* is English *good*, *Tag* is *day*, *Nacht* is *night*. The gaps between them are not random — they follow the **High German Consonant Shift** ($d \rightarrow t$, $t \rightarrow s$, $k \rightarrow ch$), a single sound-law you can learn once and then use to guess the English cousin on sight (the Romance languages have their own such laws — Latin *-ct-* became Spanish *-ch-*).

Where it lights something up, the book sets German beside its cousins — English always, and Spanish and French as Latin’s side of the family, each form supplied in full so no prior knowledge of them is needed. The richest moment is *Nacht*, where German *Nacht*, English *night*, Spanish *noche*, and French *nuit* turn out to be the same Indo-European word, split four ways.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the German out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind pronunciation. Each lesson names the one

or two sounds its own word needs, exactly where they are needed. The whole system is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

The German greetings, built from their pieces — a word for “good,” the day-parts, and the three-gender article system. Because German and English are siblings, most words are direct cousins, reshaped by the High German Consonant Shift; where it helps, Spanish and French stand alongside for contrast. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C01-*.md.*

1.1 *hallo* — “hi,” a real cousin this time

Sounds you’ll need

HAH-loh, stress on the first syllable; the *a* is short and open, the *h* fully breathed (German never drops an *h* the way French does).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hallo (informal “hi”) — unlike Spanish *hola* (a false friend), German *hallo* and English *hello* are genuine relatives, from the same Germanic hailing call (family of *holla*, *hail*). Where Spanish sends you through Rome, German sends you straight home: because English is Germanic, German words are often *direct* English cousins.

Informal-to-neutral; for polite or first meetings, German uses *Guten Tag*, built over the next lessons.

1.2 *gut* — “good,” and the shift that reshapes German

Sounds you’ll need

goot, one long *u* as in English *boot*; the final *t* stays crisp.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gut (“good”) ← Proto-Germanic **gōdaz* — the *same* word as English **good**. Why *gut*, not *good*? The **High German Consonant Shift**, rule *d*→*t*: *good* → *gut*, *day* → *Tag*, *bed* → *Bett*. Learn the shift once and you can guess the English cousin behind a German word on sight — a single regular sound-law, the same kind of trick that reshaped the Romance words too (Latin *-ct-* became Spanish *-ch-*, *noche*).

Grammar Lens

English splits *good* (adjective) from *well* (adverb); Spanish *bueno/bien*, French *bon/bien*. **German does not** — *gut* is both. “A good day” is *ein guter Tag*; “I’m well” is *mir geht’s gut*. The Romance pair collapses into one German word.

1.3 *der* / *die* / *das* — “the,” and *three* genders

Sounds you’ll need

dair / *dee* / *dahss*. The *r* of *der* is barely a vowel-like murmur at the back; *die* rhymes with English *see*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

der (m.) / **die** (f.) / **das** (n.) ← the old Germanic demonstratives **sa* / **sō* / **pat* — cousins of English **the** and **that**. Indeed **das** ↔ *that* (the shift *t*→*s*). Not Latin *ille/illa* (that gave Spanish *el/la*, French *le/la*) — Germanic all the way.

Grammar Lens

Latin’s three genders (m./f./neuter) collapsed to two in Spanish and French. **German kept all three:** *der, die, das*. So a noun is one of three classes (learn it *with* its article: *der Tag, die Nacht, das Kind*). English went the other way and dropped gender entirely. (German articles also change by *case* later — *den, dem, des*; ignore that for now.)

1.4 Tag — “day,” straight cousin of English *day***Sounds you’ll need**

tahk: long *a* as in *father*, and a final *-g* that Germans harden to a *k* at the end of a word (*final devoicing*) — so *Tag* rhymes with English *tock*, not *tag*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

der Tag (masc.) ← Proto-Germanic **dagaz* = English **day**, via the *d*→*t* shift. Note the split from Latin: Spanish *día* and French *jour* come from Latin *dies* — a *different* root from Germanic **dagaz*, which is why *día* and *Tag* look nothing alike. (And every German noun is Capitalized — *Tag*.)

Grammar Lens

der Tag is **masculine**; plural *die Tage* (“the days”). Note the article shift: *der* → *die* in the plural, whatever the gender — German, like French *les*, uses one plural article for all.

1.5 Guten Tag — assembled, and a first German ending

gut + *Tag* = “good day,” the neutral polite hello, *GOO-ten tahk*.

Grammar Lens

Why *guten*, not *gut*? German adjectives agree in gender, number, *and* case. *Guten Tag* is frozen from “[*ich wünsche Ihnen einen*] *guten Tag*” — “[I wish you a] good day,” where “a good day” is the object (accusative).

A masculine noun there takes *-en*: *guten*. (Don't master the ending system now; just bank that endings track gender+number+case, and watch *Gute Nacht* change it.)

1.6 *Morgen* — “morning,” inside English *tomorrow*

Sounds you'll need

MOR-gun: stress the first syllable; the *-en* sinks to a soft *-un*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

der Morgen (masc.) ← Proto-Germanic **murganaz* = English **morn-ing**, **morn**, and the *-morrow* of **tomorrow**. (*Morgen* alone also means “tomorrow” in German — context decides.)

Guten Morgen = *gut* + *Morgen* (masc., plural *die Morgen* — unchanged) = “good morning” — *guten* again, same as *Tag*. Used until midday, then *Guten Tag*.

1.7 *Abend* — “evening,” cousin of English *eve*

Sounds you'll need

AH-bent: first-syllable stress, and again final devoicing — the *-d* hardens to *-t*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

der Abend (masc.) ← Proto-Germanic **ābanþs* = English **eve**, **even(ing)**. Across the languages “evening” has a *different* root in each branch: Germanic *ābanþs* (*Abend*, *eve*) vs Latin “late” words — French *soir* (← *sērus*), Spanish *tarde* (← *tardus*).

Guten Abend = “good evening” (*der Abend*, masc., plural *die Abende*), *guten* once more — the third masculine day-part in a row. The arc: *Guten Morgen* → *Guten Tag* → *Guten Abend*.

1.8 *Nacht* — “night,” where all four languages meet

Sounds you’ll need

nahkht: the *ch* is the throaty *ach*-sound (a scrape at the back of the mouth, like the *ch* in Scottish *loch*), **not** an English *ch*. This is the same throat-scrape as Spanish *j* and Arabic *kh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

die Nacht (fem.) goes back to Proto-Indo-European **nókʷts* — the shared ancestor of every night-word you have. They split by each branch’s sound-laws: Germanic *kt*→*ht* (*Nacht*, *night*), Latin kept *ct* (*noctem*), Spanish softened it to *-ch-* (*noche*), French to *-it-* (*nuit*).

Branch	Word
German / English (Germanic)	Nacht / night
Spanish / French (Latin)	noche / nuit

Nacht is **feminine** (*die Nacht*; plural *die Nächte*, the *a* taking an umlaut → *ä*) — which is why “good night” breaks the *guten* streak.

1.9 *Gute Nacht* — good night, and the ending that changes

gut + *Nacht* = “good night,” *GOO-te nahkht*.

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Three greetings were *guten* (Tag, Morgen, Abend — masculine). This is *gute*: *Nacht* is **feminine**, and a feminine noun in the “(I wish you a) good —” accusative takes *-e*. So: *guten* (masc.) vs *gute* (fem.) — the German adjective reports the noun’s gender through its ending, the same job Romance adjectives do (Spanish *bueno/buena*, French *bon/bonne*).

Why it’s said this way

Like Spanish *buenas noches* and French *bonne nuit*, *Gute Nacht* is the **bedtime** farewell — not an evening hello (that’s *Guten Abend*). Next

chapter: introducing yourself, and *du* vs. *Sie* (informal vs. formal “you”).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

- *Ich heiße Mira.*
- *Wie heißen Sie?*
- *Ich heiße Arun.*
- *Freut mich.*

Built the same way as the greetings: each piece taken apart first, then assembled — and, because German is English’s sibling, most pieces are direct English cousins. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C02-*.md.*

2.1 *ich* — “I,” the same ancient word as Latin *ego*

Sounds you’ll need

ikh: the *ch* is soft here (a light hiss at the front of the mouth, the “ich-sound”), not the throat-scrape of *Nacht*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ich (“I”) ← Proto-Germanic **ik*, from Proto-Indo-European **eǵ* — the *same* deep root that gave Latin **ego** (and English **ego**), Greek *egō*, and, worn down hardest of all, English **I**. So German *ich*, Latin *ego*, and English *I* are three survivals of one Ice-Age word for “I.”

2.2 heißen — “to be called,” the verb English almost lost

Sounds you’ll need

HY-ssen. The ß (*Eszett*) is just a sharp “ss”; *ei* is the vowel of English *eye*. So *heiße* = *HY-ssuh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

heißen (“to be called / to be named”) ← Proto-Germanic **haitanā*. English had this verb too — **hight**, “named,” now archaic (“a knight *hight* Gawain”) — and it survives in **behest** (a command, something “called for”). Where the Romance languages say “I call *myself*” with a reflexive, German uses *heißen* as a plain verb of *being* called — no “myself” needed.

Grammar Lens

One verb, changing its ending. *heißen* is the dictionary (infinitive) form. For each person the ending changes: *ich heiße* (I am called), *du heißt* (you are called), *Sie heißen* (you [formal] are called). This ending-swap is the same machine you’ll see on every German verb.

2.3 ich heiße... — “my name is...,” literally “I am called”

ich (I) + *heiße* (am called) = **ich heiße...** — word for word “I am called...,” and the everyday German for “**my name is...**” *Ich heiße Arun.* = “My name is Arun.”

Why it’s said this way

German also has the literal “my name is”: **mein Name ist...** — where **Name** ← Proto-Germanic **namō*, the *same* root as English **name** and Latin *nōmen* (English **noun**, **nominate**). It’s perfectly correct and common. But *ich heiße* is warmer and more idiomatic — German prefers the *verb* (“I am called”) to the *noun* phrase. (And note *Name* is Capitalized: German capitalizes *every* noun.)

2.4 *du* / *Sie* — “you,” familiar and formal

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

du (familiar “you”) ← Proto-Germanic **pū*, from PIE **tū* — the *same* root as English archaic **thou**, Latin *tū*, and (a cousin) French *tu*. English kept it only in old prayers and Yorkshire; German uses it every day.

Grammar Lens

Two “you”s — and German’s is the odd one out. *du* is for friends, family, children, peers. For respect, German uses **Sie** — which is really the word for “they” (*sie*), promoted to a polite “you” and always **Capitalized** to mark the difference. So German is polite by addressing you in the *third person plural* (“might they...” — a third route to politeness: Spanish coined *usted* (“your grace”), French uses the second-person plural *vous* (“you all”), German borrows the third-person plural *Sie* (“they”). All three dodge the blunt, intimate “you.” When unsure, use *Sie*.

2.5 *wie* — “how,” cousin of English *how*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

wie (“how”) ← Proto-Germanic **hwī*, from the PIE interrogative root **k^wo-* — the very root behind the English *wh-* words **how**, **what**, **who**, **why** (and, through Latin, the *qu-* of *quo modo*). German *wie* and English *how* are the same question-word, lightly reshaped.

Grammar Lens

Like French (*comment*), German asks a name with “*how*,” not “*what*”: *wie heißen Sie?* is literally “*how* are you called?” Keep the German logic — the question is about the manner of your being called.

2.6 *wie heißen Sie?* — “what’s your name?”

wie (how) + *heißen Sie* (“are you [formal] called”) = literally “**how are you called?**” — the polite “what’s your name?”

Grammar Lens

Word order: verb second. German puts the verb in the *second* slot: *Wie* (1) *heißen* (2) *Sie*? The informal version just swaps in *du* and its ending: *Wie heißt du*? So the same verb, *heißen*, runs the whole exchange — *ich heiße* to give your name, *wie heißen Sie*? to ask for theirs.

2.7 *freut mich* — “pleased to meet you,” i.e. “it gladdens me”

Sounds you’ll need

froyt mikh: *eu* is the vowel of English *boy*; the final *ch* is the soft *ich*-sound again.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

freut mich is short for *es freut mich* (*Sie kennenzulernen*), “it gladdens me (to get to know you).” The verb **freuen** (“to gladden”) is built on **froh** (“glad, joyful”) — the same Germanic *froh/froh-* that surfaces in the English *Frohe Weihnachten* you see at Christmas. To say *freut mich* is to say, warmly, “this makes me glad.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mich (“me,” the object form) ← Proto-Germanic **mek*, from PIE **me-* — the *same* first-person root as English **me**, **my**, **mine** (and the French *me* of *je m’appelle*). So German *mich*, English *me*, and French *me* are three cousins of one ancient word for “me.” Just as English shifts *I* (subject) to *me* (object), German shifts *ich* to *mich*.

Grammar Lens

German is literally saying “[it] gladdens *me*” — the meeting is what does the gladdening, and you are on the receiving end (the object, *mich*). Fuller forms: *sehr erfreut* (“much pleased”), or the plain *angenehm* (“pleasant / agreeable”), both usable as “pleased to meet you.”

2.8 The whole exchange

German	English
<i>Ich heie Mira.</i>	My name is Mira.
<i>Wie heien Sie?</i>	What's your name?
<i>Ich heie Arun.</i>	My name is Arun.
<i>Freut mich.</i>	Pleased to meet you.

Every piece was a Germanic cousin of English: *ich* (I/ego), *heien* (hight/behest), *wie* (how), *freuen* (froh). And German's two habits to keep: it names with a plain verb of *being* called (no "myself"), and it is polite by the *third* person (*Sie* = "they"). Next chapter: *Wie geht's?* ("how's it going?") and answering with *gut* again — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

Having given your name, you ask after the other person — and German asks it with a verb of *motion*: *wie geht es dir?*, “how goes it to you?” Around that question sit the two courtesies that hold every conversation together, *danke* and *bitte*, each of which turns out to be an English word in disguise. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C03-*.md.*

3.1 *danke* — “thank you,” which is really “I think of you”

Sounds you’ll need

DAHN-kuh: a pure open *ah*, the final *-e* sinking to a soft *uh*. Stress the front: *DAHN-kuh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

danke ← **denken**, “to think.” The old idea: to thank someone is to *keep them in mind* — “I think of you,” “you are in my thoughts.” German *Dank* (“thanks”) and *Gedanke* (“a thought”) are the same root wearing two coats.

And here is the payoff for an English speaker: **English “thank” and “think” are the same word too.** Old English *þancian* (“thank”) and *þencan* (“think”) split from one root — to thank was to *hold in thought*. So *danke* isn’t foreign at all; it is English **thank** with the **think** still visible inside it.

Three different pictures of gratitude, worth holding side by side:

Language	“Thanks”	Literal idea
German	<i>danke</i>	“I think of you”
French	<i>merci</i>	a reward / mercy
Spanish	<i>gracias</i>	grace / favour

Grammar Lens

Dressing it up. *danke schön* — “thank you *nicely*” (*schön* = beautiful, nice) → “thank you very much.” *danke sehr* — “thanks *very*.” *vielen Dank* — “many thanks” (*viel*, “much,” comes later).

3.2 *bitte* — the Swiss-army word: “please” and “you’re welcome”

Sounds you’ll need

BIT-tuh: a short crisp *i*, a clear double-*t*, a soft *-uh* at the end.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bitte is the plea-form of **bitten**, “to ask, to request, to pray.” When you say *bitte* you are, at root, *making a request* — “I ask (this of you).” That verb *bitten* is a close cousin of two English words. **bid** — as in “I *bid* you welcome,” “do as you’re *bidden*” — to ask or command. And **bead** — astonishingly, yes: a *bead* was originally a **prayer**. People counted their prayers (Old English *gebed*) on a string, and the name of the prayer slid onto the little ball you counted it with. So a rosary *bead* is a frozen *request* — exactly what *bitte* still is.

If German gives you one word to overwork, it is *bitte*. It is “please.” It is also “you’re welcome,” and “here you go,” and even “pardon?” One word, and it all comes straight from *asking*:

You say <i>bitte</i> when...	It means	Why (it is all “I ask”)
making a request	please	“I ask you...”
answering <i>danke</i>	you’re welcome	“I ask nothing back”
handing something over	here you go	“I offer, at your request”
you didn’t hear	pardon?	“I ask you to repeat”

Why it’s said this way

For this chapter the key pairing is the courtesy loop: *Danke.* — *Bitte.* (“Thanks.” — “You’re welcome.”) It is the German twin of Spanish *de nada* and French *de rien*, and it closes every small favour.

3.3 *gehen* — “to go,” and it is just English *go***Sounds you’ll need**

In *gehen* the *h* merely **lengthens** the vowel (it is not a breathy English *h*): *GAY-en*. The form you need most is *geht* = *gayt*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gehen (“to go”) and English **go** descend from the *same* Germanic verb (**gān* / *gehen*) — no Latin detour, no false friend, a straight cognate. When you say *geht*, you are saying *goes*.

Spanish asks “how are you?” with *estar* (“to stand”). French and German both ask it with “**to go**” — *how does it go?* German states its wellbeing as *motion*, exactly like French *ça va*:

Es geht mir gut. = “It goes for-me well.” → “I’m doing well.”

Morphology Spotlight

es = “it” (cognate of English *it*).

geht = “goes.”

mir = “to me, for me” — the *dative*, the “to-whom” form; its partner is *dir*, “to you.”

gut = “well” (Chapter 1 — cognate of English *good*).

So German literally says “**it goes well to me.**” Wellbeing is something that *goes*, and it goes *to* a person.

Grammar Lens

The dative, gently. German marks *the person something happens to* with a special form: *ich* (“I”) → *mir* (“to me”); *du* (“you”) → *dir* (“to you”). “How are you?” will use *dir* or *Ihnen* — “how does it go *to you*?”

For now, just recognize *mir* = “to me.”

3.4 *Wie geht es dir?* — “how are you?”

Sounds you’ll need

German *w* says *v*, so *wie* is *vee*; *ie* is a long *ee*. The whole question: *vee gayt es deer*.

Every piece is already yours: **wie** (“how”), the **du** / **Sie** choice, and **gehen** / **geht** (“to go”). *wie* is used for manner and degree; *du* goes to a friend, and capital-S *Sie* to a stranger or an elder (it is literally “they,” borrowed as respect). Snap them together:

Wie geht es dir? = “How are you?” (informal)
literally: “How goes it to you?”

Morphology Spotlight

wie = “how” · **geht** = “goes” · **es** = “it” · **dir** = “to you” — the dative of *du*, the *mir* → *dir* pair from the last lesson.

Two registers, and only the “you” changes — the same move as the *du*/*Sie* split:

Register	Question
informal (friend, family)	<i>Wie geht es dir?</i> (spoken <i>Wie geht's dir?</i> / just <i>Wie geht's?</i>)
formal (stranger, elder)	<i>Wie geht es Ihnen?</i>

es and *dir* often crush together in speech into *geht's* — *Wie geht's?* is the everyday form, and you can answer it with the *gut* you already have: *Danke, gut!* (“Thanks, well!”).

Grammar Lens

Same question, three metaphors. German *gehen* (go): “how goes it to you?” French *aller* (go): “how does it go?” Spanish *estar* (stand): “how are you standing?” Two of the three put wellbeing in motion; Spanish puts it on its feet.

3.5 *es geht* — the German shrug: “it goes”

Someone asks *Wie geht's?* You are neither great nor terrible. German's answer is beautifully understated: **es geht** — just “it goes.” Not *well*, not *badly* — it simply *goes*. That bareness *is* the shrug.

Grammar Lens

In the last lesson you added *gut* to make it positive: *Es geht mir gut*, “it goes well for me.” Say it with **nothing added** — *es geht* — and the very absence of a “well” or “badly” makes it mean “eh, so-so, it's going, I'm getting by.” The understatement carries the whole meaning.

Your German answer ladder for *Wie geht's?*:

Answer	Sense
<i>Sehr gut!</i> / <i>Gut,</i> <i>danke</i>	very well / well, thanks
<i>Es geht</i>	so-so, okay-ish
<i>So lala</i>	so-so (a sing-song “meh”; <i>lala</i> is just filler)
<i>Nicht so gut</i>	not so well

Why it's said this way

The cross-track shrug collection, now four deep: German **es geht** (“it goes”), French **comme ci, comme ça** (“like this, like that”), Spanish **más o menos** (“more or less”) or **regular**, Italian **così così** (“so so”).

3.6 The whole exchange

No new words — this chapter's atoms (*danke, bitte, gehen, wie geht's, es geht*) assemble into a real exchange, formal and informal, picking up right where the introduction of Chapter 2 left off.

Formal (a stranger, an elder):

— *Guten Tag. Wie geht es Ihnen?*
 — *Danke, gut. Und Ihnen?*
 — *Es geht.*
 — [after a small favour] — *Danke!* — *Bitte.*

Informal (a friend):

- *Hallo! Wie geht's?*
- *Gut, danke, und dir?*
- *So lala.*

Grammar Lens

The glue is *und dir?* / *und Ihnen?* — “and you?” (*und* = “and,” cognate of English **and**), the German twin of Spanish *¿y tú?* and French *et toi?*. Note that it takes the **dative** (*dir* / *Ihnen*), because it is short for “how goes it *to you?*”

Built this chapter

<i>danke</i>	thanks (← <i>denken</i> , “to think”; English <i>thank</i> = <i>think</i>)
<i>bitte</i>	please / you’re welcome (← <i>bitten</i> , “to ask”; English <i>bid</i> , <i>bead</i>)
<i>gehen</i> / <i>geht</i>	“to go,” the state-verb (= English <i>go</i>)
<i>Wie geht es</i>	how are you — informal / formal
<i>dir?</i> / <i>Ihnen?</i>	
<i>gut</i> / <i>es geht</i> / <i>so</i>	the answer ladder
<i>lala</i> / <i>nicht so gut</i>	

Which verb carries German’s “how are you?”, and what English word is it? *gehen* = *go*. Which two of our three tracks use “to go,” and which uses “to stand”? Go: German and French; stand: Spanish. Next chapter: farewells — *auf Wiedersehen*, *tschüss*, *bis bald*.

Chapter 4

Farewells

You can open a German conversation; now close it. German parts formally with a promise to *see each other again*, casually with a word that has travelled across three languages, and softly with *bis...* — “until...” — plus a word for time. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-CO4-*.md.*

4.1 *auf Wiedersehen* — “goodbye,” i.e. “till we see again”

Sounds you’ll need

owf VEE-der-zay-en. German *w* says *v*, and *ie* is a long *ee*, so *Wieder* = *VEE-der*. Nouns are capitalized in German, so *Wiedersehen* takes a capital W.

The formal goodbye is **auf Wiedersehen**, and it is the exact twin of French *au revoir*: both mean “until we see each other again.” It breaks cleanly into three pieces:

Morphology Spotlight

auf = “on, upon” (cognate of English *up* / *of*).

wieder = “again” — not, as you might guess, kin to *withering*, but to the *with-* of **withdraw**; think “back.”

sehen = “to see” — a **straight cognate of English see** (both from Germanic **sehwan*).

So *auf Wiedersehen* = “on the seeing-again” → “until we see each other again.” Put it beside the other two tracks and the picture is lovely:

Language	Goodbye	Metaphor
German	<i>auf Wiedersehen</i>	“till we see again”
French	<i>au revoir</i>	“till the re-seeing ”
Spanish	<i>adiós</i>	“to God ”

Why it’s said this way

German and French shake hands on a *re-seeing*; Spanish commends you to God. (*Wiedersehen* even works as a noun on its own — *ein Wiedersehen* is “a reunion.”)

4.2 *tschüss* — the casual “bye” that used to say “to God”

Sounds you’ll need

tschüss starts with the *ch* of English **church**: *chüss*. The **ü** is the front-rounded vowel — say *ee* with rounded lips — so *tschüss* is roughly *chuess*, short and clipped.

Between friends, Germans rarely say the full *auf Wiedersehen* — they say **tschüss**, a breezy “bye.” And it hides one of the best secrets in this whole chapter.

Etymology

tschüss looks purely German, but trace it back and it leaves the country. French **adieu** (“to God”) → borrowed into **Walloon** (a language of southern Belgium) as **adjûs** → carried north into **Low German** dialects as **atschüs** / **atschüss** → clipped to modern **tschüss**.

So the chain is *adieu* → *adjûs* → *atschüss* → *tschüss* — and since *adieu* is à *Dieu*, “to God,” the casual German *tschüss* is a far-travelled cousin of French **adieu** (“to God”) and Spanish **adiós** (“to God”): all three the same little blessing, just worn down more and more. The friendliest, most throwaway German goodbye is secretly the most solemn one.

Why it’s said this way

You will also hear **tschau** — that one is Italian *ciao*, borrowed straight.

Grammar Lens

Register. *tschüss* — friends, family, peers, casual shops; never in a formal meeting. *auf Wiedersehen* — strangers, elders, officials, the telephone. It is the same split you have drilled all along (*du* vs *Sie*): pick the parting to match the relationship.

4.3 *bis bald* — “see you soon”**Sounds you’ll need**

bis = *biss* (short *i*). *bald* = *balt* — a final *d* always hardens to *t* in German (final devoicing). The whole phrase: *biss BALT*.

German’s soft goodbyes all start with **bis**, “until” — the German version of Spanish *hasta* and French *à*. First up: **bis bald**, “until soon” → “see you soon,” the twin of *hasta pronto* and *à bientôt*.

Morphology Spotlight

bis = “until, up to” — German’s farewell preposition. Just as Spanish builds *hasta luego* / *hasta mañana* and French builds *à bientôt* / *à demain*, German builds *bis* + a time word.

bald = “soon.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bald (“soon”) ← Old High German *bald*, which meant “**bold**, quick, brave” — and that is the *same word as English bold*. The sense drifted: what is done *boldly* is done *quickly* → *soon*. So German “soon” and English “bold” are one word; German kept the speed, English kept the courage.

Grammar Lens

The *bis...* family.

German	“Until...”	Spanish / French twin
<i>bis bald</i>	soon	<i>hasta pronto</i> / <i>à bientôt</i>
<i>bis später</i>	later	<i>hasta luego</i> / <i>à plus tard</i>
<i>bis morgen</i>	tomorrow	<i>hasta mañana</i> / <i>à demain</i>

bis später — “until later” — uses *später*, “later,” the comparative of *spät*, “late.” *bis morgen* comes next.

4.4 *bis morgen* — “see you tomorrow” (and *Morgen* comes back)

Sounds you’ll need

The German *r* is the guttural one, made at the back: *morgen* = *MOR-gen*. Whole phrase: *biss MOR-gen*.

Parting for the day: **bis morgen**, “until tomorrow.” It brings back **Morgen** — the “morning” from your very first chapter (*Guten Morgen!*) — now doing a second job.

Morphology Spotlight

bis = “until” (last lesson).

morgen = “tomorrow” and “morning,” exactly the double meaning of Spanish *mañana* and French *demain*. German simply uses the one word for both: *Guten Morgen!* = “Good **morning!**”; *bis morgen* = “until **tomorrow.**” When it means “morning” it is a capital-M noun, *der Morgen*; as “tomorrow” it is lowercase, *morgen*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Morgen is a straight relative of English **morning** and the old word **morrow** — “see you on the *morrow*” is *bis morgen* almost word for word, and “tomorrow” is literally “to (the) morrow.” So all three tracks make “tomorrow” out of “morning”: German **Morgen**, Spanish **mañana** (← Latin *māne*), French **demain** (← *dē māne*). Same idea, three routes.

Grammar Lens

The *bis...* farewells, complete. You now have German’s full soft-goodbye set — *bis bald* (soon), *bis später* (later), *bis morgen* (tomorrow) — plus *auf Wiedersehen* (formal) and *tschüss* (casual).

4.5 Saying goodbye, start to finish

No new words. The farewells now close a real conversation and fold back into everything since *hallo*.

You're...	Say
formal / to a stranger	<i>Auf Wiedersehen.</i>
casual / to a friend	<i>Tschüss.</i>
meeting again soon	<i>Bis bald.</i>
leaving for the day	<i>Bis morgen.</i>

Everything from Chapters 1–4, in one exchange:

- *Hallo! Ich heie Anna. Wie heien Sie?*
 — *Ich heie Peter. Freut mich.*
 — *Wie geht es Ihnen?*
 — *Danke, gut. Und Ihnen?*
 — *Sehr gut. Also...bis morgen, Peter.*
 — *Bis morgen, Anna. Auf Wiedersehen!*

Between friends, that last line becomes *Tschüss, bis morgen!*

Built this chapter

<i>auf Wiedersehen</i>	the formal goodbye (“on the seeing-again”; <i>sehen</i> = <i>see</i> ; twin of <i>au revoir</i>)
<i>tschüss</i>	casual bye (secretly <i>adieu</i> , “to God,” cousin of <i>adiós</i>)
<i>bis</i>	soon / later / tomorrow — <i>bis</i> + a time, like
<i>bald/ später/ morgen</i>	<i>hasta</i> and <i>à</i>

Which German goodbye promises a “re-seeing,” and which language matches it? *Auf Wiedersehen*; French *au revoir*. What does the casual *tschüss* secretly mean? “To God.” You can now hold a whole German exchange, hello to goodbye. Next chapter: the first verbs, and your first self-built sentence.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now you have assembled fixed phrases. This chapter hands you the machine itself: the regular German verb, whose endings you learn once and then apply to thousands of words. Three verbs — *wohnen*, *machen*, *lernen* — and then your first sentence built from parts nobody handed you. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C05-*.md.*

5.1 *wohnen* — “to live,” and the regular German verb

Sounds you’ll need

German *w* is an English *v*: *wohnen* = *VOH-nen*. The *h* here merely **lengthens** the *o* (*woh-* = a long *oh*); it is not breathy.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

wohnen (“to live, to dwell”) ← Old High German *wonēn*, “to dwell, to be accustomed, to be content” — dwelling and *being used to* a place were the same idea. That root survives in English, just barely: **wont**, “accustomed” (*as is his wont*), and *won’t*’s distant cousin; the archaic **won** / **wone**, “to dwell.” It is also kin to **win** and **wish** — all from a root about *striving for* or *being content*.

Grammar Lens

The regular (weak) present tense. Drop the *-en* to get the stem *wohn-*, then add the endings. This one table is the pattern behind thousands of German verbs.

Person	Ending	<i>wohnen</i> →
<i>ich</i> (I)	-e	<i>ich wohne</i>
<i>du</i> (you)	-st	<i>du wohnst</i>
<i>er / sie / es</i> (he / she / it)	-t	<i>er wohnt</i>
<i>wir</i> (we)	-en	<i>wir wohnen</i>
<i>ihr</i> (you all)	-t	<i>ihr wohnt</i>
<i>sie / Sie</i> (they / you formal)	-en	<i>sie wohnen</i>

Unlike French — where *-e*, *-es*, *-ent* are all silent — **German endings are audible**: *wohne* / *wohnst* / *wohnt* really do sound different. So you could almost tell who is speaking from the ending alone. German nevertheless *keeps* the pronoun; why, comes later in this chapter. Now you can answer a *wo* (“where”) question:

Ich wohne in Berlin. = “I live in Berlin.”

5.2 *machen* — “to make / to do,” and it is just English *make*

Sounds you’ll need

The *ch* after *a* is the raspy *ach*-sound, made in the throat like the *ch* of Scottish *loch*: *machen* = *MAKH-en*, with a clean open *ah*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

machen ← Germanic *makōn*, “to make, to shape, to fit together” — the *same word as English make*. The German *k*-sound became the *ch* rasp along the way, by the **High German consonant shift**: *make* → *machen*, just as *ik* → *ich* and *book* → *Buch*. So *machen* is *make*, wearing German pronunciation.

German uses it for both “make” and “do”:

Ich mache einen Kuchen. = “I’m making a cake.”
Was machst du? = “What are you doing?”

Grammar Lens

Same weak endings. *ich mache · du machst · er macht (-e / -st / -t); wir machen · ihr macht · sie machen.* Identical to *wohnen* — nothing new to learn. That is the payoff of a regular pattern.

Person	<i>machen</i> →
<i>ich</i>	<i>mache</i>
<i>du</i>	<i>machst</i>
<i>er / sie / es</i>	<i>macht</i>
<i>wir</i>	<i>machen</i>
<i>ihr</i>	<i>macht</i>
<i>sie / Sie</i>	<i>machen</i>

5.3 *lernen* — “to learn,” and it *is* English *learn***Sounds you’ll need**

The German **r** is a soft guttural at the back of the throat: *lernen* = *LER-nen*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

lernen ← Germanic *līznōjan*, “to learn, to get to know” — the *same root as English learn*. Its close relatives are lovely: **lore**, the body of what has been *learned* (folklore, the *lore* of a craft); and **last** (a shoemaker’s *last*) together with Gothic *lais* (“I know”), which share the deep root — the idea of *following a track* to knowledge. So *lernen* is not foreign at all: it is *learn*, and its noun *die Lehre* (“the teaching, the lesson”) is *lore*.

Grammar Lens

The same weak endings, one last time — *-e / -st / -t* in the singular, *-en / -t / -en* in the plural. Three verbs, *wohne, mache, lerne*, one pattern: you now conjugate the regular German present.

Person	<i>lernen</i> →
<i>ich</i>	<i>lerne</i>
<i>du</i>	<i>lernst</i>
<i>er / sie / es</i>	<i>lernt</i>
<i>wir</i>	<i>lernen</i>
<i>ihr</i>	<i>lernt</i>
<i>sie / Sie</i>	<i>lernen</i>

5.4 *Ich lerne Deutsch* — your first real sentence

Sounds you'll need

Deutsch = *DOYTCH*: *eu* is the *oy* vowel, and *tsch* is the *tch* of English *match*. The whole sentence: *ikh LER-neh DOYTCH*.

Everything pays off: you take a **verb** you have conjugated and a **noun**, and build a sentence nobody handed you — *Ich lerne Deutsch*, “I’m learning German.” (There is no separate “am ...-ing” in German: *ich lerne* covers both “I learn” and “I am learning.”)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Deutsch = “German” (the language), and note it is **capitalized**, because it is a noun here. It comes from Old High German **diutisc**, “of the people, of the folk” — from **peudō*, “the people.” The Germanic tribes simply called their own tongue “the people’s [language],” as opposed to Latin.

That “folk” root spread far: English **Dutch** is the *same* word (it once meant all continental West Germanic; English later narrowed it to the Netherlands); **Teutonic** comes via Latin *Teutonicus* from the same **peudō*; Italian calls Germany *Tedesco* and French had *thiois* — all echoes of *diutisc*.

Morphology Spotlight

Ich (I) + **lerne** (learn, from *lernen*) = **Ich lerne Deutsch**.

Grammar Lens

Why German keeps the pronoun. German keeps *ich, du, er...* — like French, and unlike Spanish or Italian, which drop it. But for a *different reason*. Spanish drops *yo* because *hablo* already says “I.” French keeps *je* because its endings are *silent*. German’s endings are *not* silent (*wohne* / *wohnst* / *wohnt* differ audibly) — yet German still needs the pronoun because its **grammar demands an overt subject**: a German sentence is built around the verb sitting in second position, with something before it. So: Spanish **drops**, French keeps for **sound**, German keeps for **structure**.

Swap the pieces and the pattern keeps working: *Ich wohne in Berlin.* ·
Was machst du?

5.5 Making sentences with weak verbs

For the first time you are *building* German sentences from a pattern, not reciting phrases. Run each verb through *ich* / *du* / *er*:

Verb	<i>ich</i>	<i>du</i>	<i>er</i>
<i>wohnen</i> (to live)	<i>wohne</i>	<i>wohnst</i>	<i>wohnt</i>
<i>machen</i> (to make/do)	<i>make</i>	<i>machst</i>	<i>macht</i>
<i>lernen</i> (to learn)	<i>lerne</i>	<i>lernst</i>	<i>lernt</i>

The same endings every time (**-e** / **-st** / **-t**), and — unlike French — you can *hear* them all. You still keep the pronoun, because German needs an overt subject.

Now say something real:

— *Wo wohnst du?* — *Ich wohne in Berlin. Und du?*
 — *Ich wohne in Wien. Was machst du?*
 — *Ich lerne Deutsch!* — *Sehr gut!*
 — *Danke!* — *Bitte.*

Built this chapter	
the regular (weak)	drop <i>-en</i> , add <i>-e/-st/-t/-en/-t/-en</i> ; the endings
present	are audible
<i>wohnen</i>	← <i>wonēn</i> → English <i>wont</i>
<i>machen</i>	← <i>makōn</i> → English <i>make</i> ; <i>Was machst du?</i>
<i>lernen</i>	← <i>liznōjan</i> → English <i>learn, lore</i>
<i>Ich lerne Deutsch</i>	first self-assembled sentence (<i>Deutsch</i> ← <i>diutisc</i> , “of the people” → <i>Dutch</i>)
the pronoun rule	Spanish drops <i>yo</i> ; French keeps <i>je</i> (silent endings); German keeps <i>ich</i> (structure)

What are the three singular weak endings, and are they audible? *-e / -st / -t*; yes — unlike French. Give the “I” forms of the three verbs: *ich wohne, ich mache, ich lerne*. German now moves in real sentences.

Chapter 6

Numbers One to Ten

Here is where German feels *closer to English than any Romance language does*. German’s numbers are not borrowed from Latin — they are German’s own Germanic words, and they are the near-twins of English *one, two, three, four, five*. One sound-law explains every difference. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C06-*.md.*

6.1 *eins, zwei, drei, vier, fünf* — counting to five

Sounds you’ll need

eins, zwei, drei all carry the *ei* = English “eye” sound: *eyns, tsvy, dry*.
fünf: the *ü* is “ee” said with rounded lips; *fünf* $\approx$ *fewnf*.

German	English twin	shared ancestor	Latin cousin
<i>eins</i> (1)	one (and <i>a/an</i>)	* <i>óynos</i>	<i>ūnus</i>
<i>zwei</i> (2)	two (<i>tw-</i> → <i>zw-</i>)	* <i>dwóh₁</i>	<i>duo</i>
<i>drei</i> (3)	three (<i>th-</i> → <i>d-</i>)	* <i>tréyes</i>	<i>trēs</i>
<i>vier</i> (4)	four	* <i>k^wetwóres</i>	<i>quattuor</i>
<i>fünf</i> (5)	five (<i>f...f</i>)	* <i>pénk^we</i>	<i>quīnque</i>

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

German and English are **siblings**; Latin is a **cousin**. So *drei* is not from Latin *trēs* — both descend from one prehistoric word, and **Grimm’s Law** is the recipe for the differences: an old **t** became Germanic **th/d** (*trēs* → **three** → *drei*), and an old **p** became **f** (**pénk^we* → **five** / *fünf*, while Latin kept it as *quīnque*). Say *fünf* and **five** back to back — same

word, one *p*-turned-*f* apart.

Grammar Lens

eins → *ein* / *eine* (**one = a/an**). Like English *one/an* and Spanish *uno/un*, German **eins** becomes the article **ein** (masculine/neuter) / **eine** (feminine) before a noun: *ein Kaffee* “a/one coffee,” *eine Katze* “a/one cat.” The counting form is *eins*; the article drops the -s. The other numbers do not change for the article.

6.2 *sechs, sieben, acht, neun, zehn* — finishing the count

The rest of the way to ten — and again, each is the twin of its English number, with Latin as the cousin one sound-shift away. Two of them show Grimm’s Law beautifully.

Sounds you’ll need

acht: the *ch* is the raspy back-of-throat sound (as in *Bach*): *akht*. It matches the *gh* in English *eight* — both were once a real throat sound.
neun = *noyn* (the *eu* = “oy”).

German	English twin	shared ancestor	Latin cousin
<i>sechs</i> (6)	six	* <i>swéks</i>	<i>sex</i>
<i>sieben</i> (7)	seven	* <i>septm</i>	<i>septem</i>
<i>acht</i> (8)	eight	* <i>oktō</i>	<i>octō</i>
<i>neun</i> (9)	nine	* <i>néwn</i>	<i>novem</i>
<i>zehn</i> (10)	ten	* <i>dékm</i>	<i>decem</i>

Etymology

Two showpieces of **Grimm’s Law**:

zehn ↔ **ten** ↔ *decem*: an old **d** became Germanic **t** — so Latin kept *decem*, English shifted to **ten**, and German went one hop further (*t* → *z*) to *zehn*. Same number, three snapshots of one consonant drifting.

acht ↔ **eight** ↔ *Nacht/night*: the German *-cht-* answers English *-ght-* every time (*acht/eight*, *Nacht/night*, *Licht/light*) — a fossil of a

throat sound both languages once had.

Grammar Lens

German borrowed the *months*, not the numbers. English and German both took their **month names straight from Latin** — *September, Oktober, November, Dezember* in German too. So the same “off by two” trick works: those months mean Latin **7, 8, 9, 10** (the Roman year began in March), even though German’s own numbers *sieben/acht/neun/zehn* look nothing like them. The numbers are home-grown; the month labels are Latin imports.

Give 1–10 in German: *eins, zwei, drei, vier, fünf, sechs, sieben, acht, neun, zehn*. None of them is borrowed from Latin — they are Germanic **twins** of the English numbers, cousins of Latin via **Grimm’s Law**. Next chapter builds on this toward the days of the week, and after that, telling the time.

Chapter 7

The Days of the Week

Just as with the numbers, German goes its **Germanic** way here — and lands right next to English. The Romans named the weekdays for planet-gods (*Mars, Mercury, Jupiter, Venus*); the Germanic peoples swapped in *their own* gods, and German and English inherited that same set. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C07-*.md.*

7.1 Montag to Freitag — the gods of the Germanic week

Sounds you'll need

-tag (“day”) is easy; watch *Freitag* = *FRY-tahk*, with the *ei* = English “eye.”

Mittwoch ends in the raspy *ch*: *MIT-vokh*.

Morphology Spotlight

The pattern: [Germanic god] + *Tag* (“day”). **Tag** = “day” (cousin of English **day**). Before it stands a god — the Germanic counterpart of the Roman planet.

German	god	= English	(Roman planet it replaced)
<i>Montag</i>	the Moon (<i>Mond</i>)	Monday	Moon
<i>Dienstag</i>	Tiw/Ziu , the war-god	Tuesday	Mars
<i>Mittwoch</i>	(none — “mid-week”)	Wednesday (Woden)	Mercury
<i>Donnerstag</i>	Donar = Thor (<i>Donner</i> “thunder”)	Thursday	Jupiter
<i>Freitag</i>	Frija/Frigg , love-goddess	Friday	Venus

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

***Donnerstag* ↔ Thursday.** *Donner* is German for “thunder,” and *Donar* was the Germanic thunder-god — the one the Norse called **Thor**. So *Donnerstag* = “Thor’s day” = **Thursday**, standing in for the Roman *Jupiter* (the sky-thunder king). Same god-slot, three names.

Why it’s said this way

***Mittwoch* is the odd one out.** It ought to be “Wodan’s day” (as English keeps **Wednesday** = Woden’s day). But the medieval Church disliked naming a day for the chief pagan god, so German replaced it with plain **Mittwoch**, “mid-week” — a religious edit, just like Portuguese numbering its days.

7.2 *Samstag* and *Sonntag* — the German weekend

Two weekend days, and one more surprise: German’s Saturday is *not* Saturn’s day — it is the **Sabbath**, sharing its root with the Romance languages, not with English *Saturday*. Sunday, though, stays the Sun’s.

German	←	meaning	note
<i>Samstag</i>	<i>Sabbat</i> ← Greek <i>sábbaton</i> ← Hebrew <i>shabbāt</i>	the “ Sabbath ”	<i>not</i> Saturn!
<i>Sonntag</i>	<i>Sun</i> + <i>Tag</i> (<i>Sonne</i> “sun”)	“the Sun ’s day”	= English Sunday

Etymology

Samstag surprises everyone: where English kept the Roman planet (**Saturday** = Saturn), German took the **Sabbath** — Greek *sábbaton* (from Hebrew *shabbāt*, “to rest”) travelled up through the early Church into German as *Sabbat* → *Samstag*. It reached German through Greek-speaking Christians. So German *Samstag* and Spanish *sábado* are the *same* Sabbath, while English alone still points at Saturn.

Why it’s said this way

In northern Germany you also hear **Sonnabend**, “Sun-eve,” the evening before Sunday.

Sonntag is simply “the **Sun**’s day,” *Sonne* + *Tag* — the exact twin of English **Sunday**. Here Germanic and English agree, and the Church did not rename it (unlike Romance, which made it “the Lord’s day,” *domingo/dimanche*). It is a rare Germanic day the Church left alone.

All seven, in order: *Montag*, *Dienstag*, *Mittwoch*, *Donnerstag*, *Freitag*, *Samstag*, *Sonntag*. German names its days for *gods*, like English, not for planets — with two edits: *Mittwoch* (“mid-week,” for Woden) and *Samstag* (the Sabbath, for Saturn). Next chapter builds on this toward telling the time.

Chapter 8

Telling the Time

Something new happens here. German's numbers were homegrown (*eins*, *zwei*), and its weekdays were Germanic gods (*Donnerstag*). But its word for the **clock** — **Uhr** — is borrowed from Latin, while noon and midnight swing back to native German. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C08-*.md.*

8.1 *Uhr* — the clock, and a Roman word in the German day

Time-keeping came to the German world with Roman and monastic clocks, and the Latin word rode in with them.

Sounds you'll need

Uhr = *oor*, a long *u* then a soft *r*: one syllable.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Uhr comes from Latin **hōra**, “hour” — the *same* word that became French *heure*, Italian *ora*, and English **hour**. German took it in (through medieval Latin and Low German *ūr(e)*) and made it *Uhr*.

That is the striking part: three layers of the German day, three different origins.

what	German	origin
the numbers	<i>eins, zwei, drei</i>	native Germanic (twins of English)
the weekdays	<i>Montag, Donnerstag</i>	Germanic gods (Latin <i>months</i>)
the clock	<i>Uhr</i>	Latin loan (<i>hōra</i>)

German kept its own numbers and gods, but for the *machine that measures hours* it reached for Rome. German also has a native word, **Stunde**, “an hour’s span” — but for clock-reading, “o’clock,” it is *Uhr*.

Grammar Lens

“***Es ist ... Uhr.***” To tell the time, German says **es ist** (“it is”) + the number + **Uhr**:

Es ist ein Uhr. — “It is one o’clock.”

Es ist zwei Uhr. — “It is two o’clock.”

Es ist zehn Uhr. — “It is ten o’clock.”

Uhr does not add a plural here (not *zwei Uhren* for the time) — it works like English **o’clock**: *zwei Uhr* = “two o’clock.” (*Uhren*, the plural, means “clocks,” the objects.)

8.2 *Mittag* and *Mitternacht* — the native middle of day and night

The clock-word *Uhr* was Latin. But noon and midnight swing back to **native German**: *Mittag* and *Mitternacht* are plain Germanic compounds — “the day’s middle” and “the night’s middle.”

Morphology Spotlight

Both start with **Mitte**, “middle” (cousin of English **mid**, **middle**, and of Latin *medius*).

German	=	literally
<i>Mittag</i>	<i>Mitte</i> + <i>Tag</i>	“ mid-day ” (noon)
<i>Mitternacht</i>	<i>Mitter</i> (<i>Mitte</i>) + <i>Nacht</i>	“ mid-night ” (midnight)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Mittag = “mid-day.” *Tag* (“day”) you met in *Montag*, *Dienstag*; put “middle” in front and you get noon. Its meaning matches French *midi* (*medius diēs*) exactly — same idea, but German built it from its *own* words instead of borrowing the Latin one.

Mitternacht = “mid-night.” *Nacht* (“night”) is the twin of English **night** (remember *acht/eight*, *Nacht/night* — the *-cht/-ght* pair). So

Mitternacht and English **midnight** are the same compound in two Germanic tongues.

To tell the time with them: *Es ist Mittag.* — “It is noon.” *Es ist Mitternacht.* — “It is midnight.”

So German splits the day three ways by origin: **Uhr** (Latin) for the hours, **Mittag/Mitternacht** (native) for its pivots. Next chapter builds on this toward months and family.

Chapter 9

Months and Seasons

The German year is built from two different quarries. Its twelve *months* were carried north from Rome, name and all; its four *seasons* are homegrown Germanic, one of them the twin of English **harvest**. This chapter walks both halves and shows where the seam runs. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C09-*.md.*

9.1 *die Monate* — Rome’s calendar in German

German’s numbers are homegrown (*eins, zwei*), and its weekday-gods are Germanic (*Donnerstag*, Thor’s day). But its **months** — like its clock-word **die Uhr** — are **borrowed straight from Latin**. Time-reckoning, again, came to the German world from Rome.

German	← Latin	who / what
<i>Januar</i>	<i>Januarius</i>	Janus , god of doors and beginnings
<i>Februar</i>	<i>Februarius</i>	the <i>Februa</i> purification festival
<i>März</i>	<i>Martius</i>	Mars , the war-god
<i>April</i>	<i>Aprilis</i>	perhaps <i>aperire</i> , “to open”
<i>Mai</i>	<i>Maius</i>	Maia , goddess of growth
<i>Juni</i>	<i>Junius</i>	Juno , queen of the gods
<i>Juli</i>	<i>Julius</i>	Julius Caesar
<i>August</i>	<i>Augustus</i>	the emperor Augustus
<i>September</i>	<i>september</i>	“ 7th ” (<i>septem</i>)
<i>Oktober</i>	<i>october</i>	“ 8th ” (<i>octo</i>)
<i>November</i>	<i>november</i>	“ 9th ” (<i>novem</i>)
<i>Dezember</i>	<i>december</i>	“ 10th ” (<i>decem</i>)

Etymology

März = Mars. German borrowed the Roman war-god’s month whole — the same god behind English **March** and behind French *mardi*. And that same god stands behind German’s own *Dienstag* (“Tuesday”), where the Romans’ Mars was *translated* into the Germanic god Tiw. The god came in twice: once by name (*März*), once by translation (*Dienstag*).

Etymology

September–Dezember = 7–10. Even in German these keep the Latin numbers *septem*, *octo*, *novem*, *decem* — because the Roman year began in March, so the “seventh” month was September. German’s *own* numbers are *sieben*, *acht*, *neun*, *zehn* — but its *month* names count in Latin.

Why it’s said this way

Three layers of the German calendar, three origins: the **numbers** are native, the **weekdays** are Germanic gods, and the **months** (along with the clock-word *Uhr*) are Latin.

9.2 *die Jahreszeiten* — the seasons go native

The months were Latin. The **seasons** swing back to **native German** — and one of them, *Herbst*, is the same word as English **harvest**. The word for “season” itself is transparent: **Jahres-zeit** = “year-time.”

German	built from	English twin
<i>der Frühling</i> (spring)	<i>früh</i> “early” + <i>-ling</i>	the “early”-season
<i>der Sommer</i> (summer)	native Germanic	summer
<i>der Herbst</i> (autumn)	native Germanic	harvest
<i>der Winter</i> (winter)	native Germanic	winter

All four are homegrown Germanic, and three are the plain twins of English *summer*, *winter*, and — the surprise — **harvest**.

Morphology Spotlight

Frühling is built from **früh** (“early”), a cousin of English **early**, plus the ending *-ling*: literally the “early-season,” the year’s first. (German

also has **der Lenz**, an old poetic word for spring.)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Herbst ↔ **harvest**. They are the same Germanic word: the *reaping* season. English kept *harvest* but narrowed it to the *act* of gathering, and reached for the Latin-derived **autumn** to name the season; German kept the old word for the season itself. Two languages, one word, split in meaning.

Why it's said this way

So the German year splits cleanly: **Latin** for the months (like *die Uhr*, the clock), **native Germanic** for the seasons (like the numbers, and like *Mittag* “midday” and *Mitternacht* “midnight”).

Chapter 10

Family

The months were Latin tourists. Family is the opposite story: German's words for father, mother, brother and sister were never borrowed — they are inherited, and they are blood cousins of the English ones. Along the way they put a famous sound-law on display. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C10-*.md.*

10.1 *der Vater, die Mutter* — the pair that proves Grimm's law

Sounds you'll need

der Vater is said *FAH-ter*: note the spelling **V**, but it is pronounced **f**.
die Mutter is said *MOO-ter*, with a short *u* as in English *put*.

Two words, with their articles:

German	English	from
<i>der Vater</i> (masculine)	father	PIE <i>*ph₂tér</i>
<i>die Mutter</i> (feminine)	mother	PIE <i>*méh₂tēr</i>

Grammar Lens

Grimm's law, on display. Grimm's law is the great sound-shift that split the **Germanic** languages (English, German, Dutch...) off from the rest of the family. Watch what it did to the *same* ancient words that Latin kept as *pater* and *māter*:

ph₂tér* → Latin *pater* (French *père*) vs. Germanic **father / **Vater**

méh₂tēr* → Latin *māter* (French *mère*) vs. Germanic **mother / **Mutter**

Etymology

p → **f**: Latin kept the *p* (*pater*); Germanic turned it into *f* — English **father**, German **Vater** (where the *V* is simply an old spelling of that *f* sound).

t → **th** → **d**: the middle consonant became English *th* (**mother**), and then, in German’s own later shift, *d/t* (**Mutter**).

Why it’s said this way

So German and English *agree* here — both start with *f*-, both with *m*- — precisely because they are **both Germanic**, while French and Latin sit on the other side of Grimm’s line. The month names were Latin tourists; *Vater* and *Mutter* are natives.

10.2 *der Bruder, die Schwester* — and the word for “siblings”

Sounds you’ll need

BROO-der; and **Schwester** is *SHVES-ter* — German *sch* spells an English *sh* sound, and the *w* that follows is said *v*, so *Schw-* = *shv-*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

der Bruder (“brother”) ← PIE **b^hréh₂tēr* — the same root as Latin *frāter* (French *frère*), but here kept with a *b-* (Grimm’s law changed *b^h* → *b*), exactly like English **brother**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

die Schwester (“sister”) ← PIE **swésōr*. The German *sch* spells an *sh* sound; strip it back and *Schwester* is English *sister* and Latin *soror* — all one root.

Morphology Spotlight

The collective — *die Geschwister*. German has a tidy word English lacks: **die Geschwister** = “**siblings**,” brothers-and-sisters together. It is built with the **ge-** prefix, an old **collective** marker (“a set of...”) attached to *Schwester* — the same *ge-* that bundles mountains into a **das Gebirge** (“a mountain range”), and that lets German gather a whole family into one word.

The four family words now stand as a Germanic set beside the Romance ones:

German	English	Romance
<i>Vater</i> / <i>Mutter</i>	father / mother	<i>père</i> / <i>mère</i>
<i>Bruder</i> / <i>Schwester</i>	brother / sister	<i>frère</i> / <i>sœur</i>

Why it's said this way

Why do these match English so closely? Because both languages are **Germanic**, drawing on the same ancient roots with no Grimm's-law gap between them. Months were *borrowed* from Latin; family is *inherited* Germanic.

Chapter 11

Bread, Water, Wine

Three words from the table, and three different histories. Two of them German speakers have always had; one of them Rome carried north together with the plant it came from. On the way, the last of German's three genders finally appears. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C11-*.md.*

11.1 *das Brot* — bread, and the third gender

Sounds you'll need

broht, with a long *o* as in English *boat*; the German *r* is made far back, in the throat.

Where the Romance sisters all say a version of Latin *pānis* (French *pain*, Italian *pane*), German goes its **own Germanic way**: *Brot*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

das Brot (“bread”) ← old Germanic **braudam* — the same word that became English **bread**. No Latin here: this is a **native** word, like *Vater* and *Wasser*, out of the Germanic core the two languages share.

Grammar Lens

The third gender — *das*. You have met **der** (masculine, *der Vater*) and **die** (feminine, *die Mutter*). German has a **third**: **das**, the **neuter** — and *Brot* is one of its nouns: **das Brot**. So the article set is now complete: **der / die / das**.

Why it's said this way

German nouns are also always **Capitalized** — *Brot*, *Vater*, *Wasser* — a rule no other language in this book follows.

11.2 *das Wasser, der Wein* — one word Germans always had, one Rome brought

Two drinks, two very different histories. *Wasser* is a word Germanic speakers have **always had**; *Wein* is one Rome **carried north** with the grapevine. Side by side, they show the difference between an *inherited* word and an ancient *loan*.

Sounds you'll need

In German the letter **w** is pronounced **v**: *Wasser* = *VAH-ser*, *Wein* = *vine*. And **ei** is always said like English *eye*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

das Wasser (“water”) — the Grimm’s-law twin of English **water**: the same Germanic root **watar*, the same core meaning, both native. Like *Brot* and *Vater*, no Latin needed — and neuter, **das Wasser**.

Etymology

der Wein (“wine”) — here is the twist: *Wein* is **not** a native Germanic word. It was **borrowed from Latin *vīnum*** in Roman times, when the legions brought **viticulture** north of the Alps. The Germanic tribes took the drink *and its name* — which is exactly why English **wine**, German **Wein**, and Latin *vīnum* all match: they are one **loan**, not three cousins. (Masculine: *der Wein*.)

Why it's said this way

The lesson in one line: *Wasser* is a word Germans **always had**; *Wein* is a word Rome **gave** them — the vine came with a vocabulary.

German	English	history
<i>das Brot</i>	bread	inherited Germanic (<i>*braudam</i>)
<i>das Wasser</i>	water	inherited Germanic (<i>*watar</i>)
<i>der Wein</i>	wine	borrowed from Latin <i>vīnum</i>

Chapter 12

Numbers Eleven to Twenty

Why are English *eleven* and *twelve* so strange? Why not “oneteen, twoteen”? German has the same oddity. Because the two languages are Germanic twins, learning one *explains* the other. At thirteen, both settle into a rule that never breaks. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C12-*.md.*

12.1 *elf* und *zwölf* — “one left over,” “two left over”

Sounds you’ll need

elf is said as it looks. *zwölf* begins *tsv*- (German *z* = *ts*, *w* = *v*) and carries the rounded *ö*: shape your lips for *oh* and say *eh*.

Morphology Spotlight

elf (11) ← old Germanic *ainlif* = *ain* (“one”) + *lif*.

zwölf (12) ← *twalif* = *twa* (“two”) + *lif*.

And **-lif** means “**to leave, to remain.**” So *elf* = “**one left over**” and *zwölf* = “**two left over.**”

Left over from **what**? From **ten** — from your ten fingers. You count to ten, you run out of fingers, and you have **one left**. Eleven is literally the leftover.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

English says exactly the same thing: *eleven* ← *ain-lif*, *twelve* ← *twa-lif*. Not similar words — *the same words*, inherited side by side. The Germanic-twin pattern that turned up in *Vater/father* and *Wasser/water* reaches even the counting.

Grammar Lens

And then it stops. The leftover-trick covers only **two** numbers. From **13** on, German turns completely regular — and so does English.

12.2 *dreizehn* → *zwanzig* — the pattern that never breaks

After the two leftovers, German settles into a rule so regular you can generate every number without being taught it: **digit** + **zehn**. And English does the identical thing — because *-teen* **is** *ten*.

	German	English	build
13	<i>dreizehn</i>	thirteen	<i>drei</i> + <i>zehn</i>
14	<i>vierzehn</i>	fourteen	<i>vier</i> + <i>zehn</i>
15	<i>fünfzehn</i>	fifteen	<i>fünf</i> + <i>zehn</i>
16	<i>sechzehn</i>	sixteen	<i>sechs</i> + <i>zehn</i> (the <i>s</i> drops)
17	<i>siebzehn</i>	seventeen	<i>sieben</i> + <i>zehn</i> (shortened)
18	<i>achtzehn</i>	eighteen	<i>acht</i> + <i>zehn</i>
19	<i>neunzehn</i>	nineteen	<i>neun</i> + <i>zehn</i>
20	<i>zwanzig</i>	twenty	← <i>twaintig</i> , “two tens”

Sounds you’ll need

The *z* of *zehn* and *zwanzig* is *ts*: *TSAYN*, *TSVAHN-tsikh*. The final *-ig* of *zwanzig* is normally said like the soft *ich*-sound, *-ikh*.

Every one of them is a digit + *zehn* — and the English column is the same compound with *-teen*, which is just **ten** again (*thir-teen* = “three-ten”). Only two small wearings-down: *sech(s)zehn* and *sieb(en)zehn* clip a sound for easier speech, exactly as English *thir-* and *fif-* did to *three* and *five*.

Morphology Spotlight

zwanzig (20) ← *twaintig*, “**two tens**” — the *-zig* is another worn-down form of *ten*, matching English *twen-ty*, whose *-ty* is *ten* as well.

Why it’s said this way

The contrast worth noticing. The Romance sisters all **break** their pattern partway through the teens — Portuguese at 16, French and Italian at 17, swapping over to a “ten-and-six” style. **German never breaks.** Two leftovers, then one clean rule all the way to twenty — and English marches beside it the entire distance.

Chapter 13

Colours

Four colours — *schwarz*, *weiß*, *rot*, *blau* — and a small surprise inside them. German’s colour words are all home-grown Germanic, with no Latin borrowed in; and two of them travelled the other way, out of Germanic and into the Romance languages. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C13-*.md.*

13.1 *schwarz*, *weiß* — black and white, and the word German lent away

German’s colour words are **home-grown** — no Latin here. But one of them has a sibling that emigrated: a German word for “shining” became the word for **white** in French, Italian and Portuguese.

Sounds you’ll need

schwarz = *SHVARTS*: the *schw*- cluster is “sh” + “v,” and the final *z* is always “ts.”

weiß = *vice*: German *w* is English “v,” *ei* is the vowel of English *eye*, and the *ß* (*Eszett*) is a sharp “ss.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

schwarz (“black”) ← Proto-Germanic **swartaz*. Its English cousin survives in **swarthy** (“dark-complexioned”). Further back it is related to Latin *sordēs* (“dirt”) — the root of English **sordid**. Black and grubby, from one idea.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

weiß (“white”) ← Proto-Germanic **hwītaz* — *exactly* English **white**.
The same word in different spelling clothes.

Sounds you’ll need

The *ß* (*Eszett*) marks a sharp *s* after a long vowel. So *weiß* rhymes with English *vice*, not with the second half of *vice-versa*. In Switzerland you will see it written **weiss** — the letter is optional there.

The word that emigrated

German also has **blank** — “shiny, polished, bare.” That word, in its Frankish form *blank* (“shining”), was **borrowed into Romance**, where it pushed Latin’s own *albus* out and became:

Language	“white”
French	blanc
Italian	bianco
Portuguese	branco
German	<i>blank</i> — still just “ shiny ”

Why it’s said this way

This is the **reverse** of the usual flow. Latin normally lends *to* Germanic (*Fenster* ← *fenestra*, *Wein* ← *vīnum*). Here Germanic lent *to* Latin’s daughters — and German kept the original meaning while they turned it into a colour.

Practise them on something you can already name: *der Wein ist weiß* (“the wine is white”), and *weiß* · *white* said side by side, so you can hear that it is one word.

13.2 *rot, blau* — an ancient cousin and a second emigrant

Two more native German colours. One is related to the French word for red — genuinely, not by borrowing. The other is a **second** German word the Romance languages took.

Sounds you'll need

rot = *roht*, with a long “o” as in English *road*.

blau = *blow* (rhyming with *cow*): German *au* is the vowel of English *house*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

rot ← Proto-Germanic **raudaz* ← Proto-Indo-European **h₁rewd^h*-. That root is one of the oldest colour words we can reconstruct, and it went everywhere:

Language	Word
German	rot
English	red , <i>rust</i> , <i>ruddy</i>
Latin	<i>ruber</i> , <i>rubeus</i> → French rouge , <i>ruby</i> , <i>rubric</i>

So *rot* and *rouge* are **cousins**, not borrowings — they split apart thousands of years before either language existed. Red is the colour humans name first, after black and white.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

blau ← Proto-Germanic **blēwaz*. Like *blank* in the last lesson, this word was **borrowed into Romance**.

Language	“blue”
German	blau
French	bleu
Italian	blu
English	blue — taken from French , not from German

Why it's said this way

English is the odd one here: it had Germanic *blāw* available but borrowed the French form instead. The word went Germanic → French → English, coming home in disguise. Portuguese went a different way entirely — its blue is **azul**, from **Arabic**.

The chapter in one table

German	Source	Did Romance borrow it?
<i>schwarz</i>	Germanic <i>*swartaz</i>	no
<i>weiß</i>	Germanic <i>*hwītaz</i>	no — but <i>blank</i> went instead
<i>rot</i>	Germanic <i>*raudaz</i>	no — Latin had its own cousin
<i>blau</i>	Germanic <i>*blēwaz</i>	yes — <i>bleu</i> , <i>blu</i>

Say all four together — *schwarz*, *weiß*, *rot*, *blau* — and then the cousins that prove the family: *rot* · *red* · *rouge*. Next chapter: putting these onto the things you already name.

Chapter 14

To Have, and How Old You Are

German's workhorse verb *haben*, “to have” — which hides the best false cognate in the whole course — and then the one everyday sentence where German *refuses* to use it, siding with English against every Romance sister. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C14-*.md.*

14.1 *haben* — “to have,” the twin of English *have*

Sounds you'll need

HAH-ben, with a long “a” as in English *father*. In *hast* and *hat* the vowel stays short and the final *t* is crisp.

Singular	Plural
ich habe	wir haben
du hast	ihr habt
er/sie hat	sie/Sie haben

Morphology Spotlight

Mostly regular, with **two irregulars**: *du hast* and *er hat* **drop the b**. English does the identical thing — *have* but *has*, and *hast* in older English. Two languages, one shortcut, inherited together.

The trap: *haben* is not *habēre*

Language	Verb	Meaning
German	haben	to have
Latin	habēre	to have

Same consonants, same meaning. **They are not related.** It is a coincidence — one of the most famous in linguistics.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

haben ← Germanic **habjaną* ← Proto-Indo-European **kap-*, “**to seize**.” That root’s Latin child is *capere* — which gives English **capture**, **captive**, **capable**, **accept**.

habēre ← Proto-Indo-European **ǵʰabh-*, whose English descendant is... **give**.

So German *haben* is a cousin of **capture**, and Latin *habēre* — the source of French *avoir* and Italian *avere* — is a cousin of **give**. The two words that look most alike come from **opposite** directions.

Using it

German nouns are capitalised and take their gender:

Ich habe einen Bruder. — “I have a brother.”
Wir haben Brot und Wein. — “We have bread and wine.”

Say the whole set aloud — *ich habe, du hast, er hat, wir haben, ihr habt, sie haben* — listening for the dropped **b**: *habe ... hast ... hat*.

14.2 *ich bin zwanzig Jahre alt* — being your years

You have just learned *haben*. Here is the everyday sentence where German **won’t** let you use it — and where German and English stand alone against all four Romance languages.

Wie alt bist du? — literally “How old are you?”
Ich bin zwanzig Jahre alt. — “I am twenty years old.”

Word for word, that is the **English sentence**. Not a coincidence — both languages inherited the same way of saying it. You can shorten it to *Ich bin zwanzig*, exactly as English drops “years old.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Jahr ← Germanic **jēra* = English **year**.

alt ← Germanic **aldaz* = English **old**.

Alt has a Latin cousin too: *alere*, “to nourish, grow” — which gives English **adult** (“grown up”) and **old** itself. Growing and ageing, one idea.

Morphology Spotlight

Jahre is the plural of *Jahr*, and German capitalises it because it is a noun. The same word sits inside *Jahreszeiten* — “year’s-times,” the German word for the seasons.

The split, laid out

Language	How age works	Literally
German	<i>ich bin ... Jahre alt</i>	I am ...
English	<i>I am twenty</i>	I am ...
French	<i>j'ai vingt ans</i>	I have ...
Spanish	<i>tengo veinte años</i>	I have ...
Italian	<i>ho venti anni</i>	I have ...
Portuguese	<i>tenho vinte anos</i>	I have ...

Why it’s said this way

Romance has its years; Germanic is its years. Age as something you carry versus age as something you are — and German, which borrowed its month names from Latin, keeps its **own** logic here. The verb it uses is *sein* (*bin*), not *haben*; that verb gets a chapter of its own shortly.

Chapter 15

The Two Past Tenses

German has two ways of talking about the past: the *Perfekt*, built from *haben* plus a wrapped-up participle, and the *Präteritum*, a single word with a *-te* on the end. They mean the same thing. What separates them is where you are and whether you are writing. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C15-*.md.*

15.1 *ich habe gesagt* — the past built from “have”

German’s everyday past tense works almost exactly like the English perfect — except for two things German does that English doesn’t.

Morphology Spotlight

The recipe: **haben** (conjugated) + **past participle**, and the participle goes **last**.

Infinitive	Participle
<i>sagen</i>	gesagt
<i>machen</i>	gemacht
<i>lernen</i>	gelernt
<i>wohnen</i>	gewohnt

Regular (weak) verbs take **ge-** in front and **-t** behind. The participle is **wrapped**, not merely suffixed — what grammarians call a *circumfix*.

German	English
<i>ich habe gesagt</i>	I said
<i>du hast gesagt</i>	you said
<i>wir haben gesagt</i>	we said

Grammar Lens

1. The participle goes to the end. Not next to the verb — the *end of the clause*:

*Ich habe gestern Deutsch **gelernt**.*

(word for word: “I have yesterday German **learned**.”)

Everything else piles up in the middle, and the participle waits at the back. English cannot do this: “I have yesterday German learned” is not a sentence.

2. It means the plain past. *Ich habe gesagt* translates as “**I said**,” not only “I have said.” Where English keeps *I said* and *I have said* apart, spoken German mostly uses the *Perfekt* for both.

The *ge-* that English lost**The word, taken apart — and its English cousins**

ge- ← Germanic **ga-*, a prefix meaning “**together, completely**.” It marked an action as **finished** — perfective — which is exactly what a past participle is for. English had it too, as *y-*, and then dropped it. Two fossils survive:

Word	Hiding inside
enough	Old English <i>genōg</i>
<i>yclept</i> (archaic, “named”)	<i>gecleopod</i>

So English once wrapped its participles the same way, and German simply never stopped. Say the wrap out loud — **ge-sag-t** — and then the fossil: *en-ough* ← *genōg*.

15.2 *ich sagte* — the simple past

German has a **second** past tense, the *Präteritum* — and choosing between the two is about **where you are** and **whether you are writing**, not about meaning.

	<i>Präteritum</i>	<i>Perfekt</i>
I said	<i>ich sagte</i>	<i>ich habe gesagt</i>
I made	<i>ich machte</i>	<i>ich habe gemacht</i>
I had	<i>ich hatte</i>	<i>ich habe gehabt</i>

Weak verbs add **-te**. Same meaning as the *Perfekt*; different register.

Morphology Spotlight

That **-te** is the **dental preterite** — the Germanic way of making a past tense by adding a *t/d* sound:

German: *sag* → *sagte*

English: *walk* → *walked*

Dutch: *werk* → *werkte*

This is a **Germanic invention**. Latin had nothing like it — Romance builds its past from inherited perfect endings instead. So *sagte* and *walked* are the same machinery, and French *parla* or Spanish *habló* are a completely different one.

Who says which

Tense	Where it lives
<i>Perfekt</i>	everyday speech — dominant, especially in the south
<i>Präteritum</i>	rarer in speech; standard in narrative writing

The *Präteritum* has largely vanished from conversation in southern Germany, Austria and Switzerland. Further north it survives better; in books, it is the normal past tense. A few verbs resist everywhere: *war*, *hatte*, and the modal verbs stay common even in speech.

The same retreat, three times

Language	Simple past	Replaced in speech by
German	<i>Präteritum</i>	<i>Perfekt</i>
French	<i>passé simple</i>	<i>passé composé</i>
Italian	<i>passato remoto</i>	<i>passato prossimo</i>

Why it's said this way

Two Romance languages and one **Germanic** one, doing the same thing over the same centuries — and **not** by coincidence. Southern Germany, France and northern Italy are **neighbours**, and the change spread through that connected block by **contact**. Linguists call this an *areal* change: it travels across language boundaries because the speakers do, which is why a Germanic language and two Romance ones line up here while Spanish and Portuguese, out at the **western edge**, largely kept their simple past. It also explains the map *inside* German: the *Präteritum* is weakest in the **south**, nearest the centre of the change, and strongest in the north.

Practise the pair back to back — *ich **sagte** ... ich **habe gesagt**, Er machte das ... Er hat das gemacht* — and hear that nothing about the meaning has moved. Next: the verbs that build their perfect with *sein*, not *haben*.

Chapter 16

To Be, and the Past That Takes It

sein, “to be” — the partner of *haben*, and the most irregular verb in German, because it is not really one verb at all but three ancient ones sharing a paradigm. Then the second half of the past tense: the family of verbs that builds its perfect on *sein* instead of *haben*. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C16-*.md.*

16.1 *sein* — “to be,” three verbs under one roof

Sounds you’ll need

sein = *zine*: German *s* before a vowel is English “z,” and *ei* is the vowel of English *eye*. In *ist* and *bist* the final *t* is crisp; *ich* ends in the soft ich-sound.

Singular	Plural
ich bin	wir sind
du bist	ihr seid
er/sie/es ist	sie/Sie sind

Past: *ich war*, *du warst*, *er war*, *wir waren*.

Look at that with fresh eyes. *Bin*, *ist*, *war* — those do not look like forms of the same word, and they aren’t.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ist, **sind**, **seid**, **sein** ← Proto-Indo-European **h₁es-*, “to be” — which also gave Latin *est*, *sunt* and French *est*, *sont*.

bin, **bist** ← **b^huH-*, “to grow, become” — which also gave English **be**

and Latin *fuī*.

war, waren ← **wes-*, “to dwell, remain” — which also gave English **was, were**.

Morphology Spotlight

Three separate ancient verbs, each contributing a slice of the paradigm. When one verb’s forms are filled in from another verb, that is **suppletion** — the same thing English does in *go / went*.

Why it’s said this way

And notice that *bin/bist* has a cousin further afield. Latin *fuī* is the source of Spanish **fui**, “I was / I went.” German *bin* and Spanish *fui* descend from the same PIE root **b^huH-* — one landed in the present, the other in the past.

Grammar Lens

Why “be” verbs are the messiest words in every language. This is not bad luck; it is a rule: *the most-used words are the most irregular*. Regularity spreads by analogy — you meet an unfamiliar verb and guess its forms from the pattern. But you never have to guess at “to be.” You hear it a hundred times a day, so the odd old shapes are reinforced faster than analogy can sand them down. Rare words get regularized; common words are protected fossils.

Run the six forms until they are automatic — *ich bin, du bist, er ist, wir sind, ihr seid, sie sind* — and put them to work: *Ich bin müde* (“I am tired”), *Das ist gut* (“that is good”).

16.2 *ich bin gegangen* — the perfect built on *sein*

The last chapter built the perfect with *haben*: *ich habe gelernt*. A particular family of verbs takes **sein** instead — and the line it draws will look familiar to anyone who has met French.

Grammar Lens

The rule: verbs of motion and change of state take *sein*.

gehen (“to go”) is the model:

German	English
<i>ich bin gegangen</i>	I went / I have gone
<i>du bist gegangen</i>	you went
<i>er ist gegangen</i>	he went
<i>wir sind gegangen</i>	we went

The rest of the family:

Verb	Perfect	English
<i>kommen</i>	<i>ich bin gekommen</i>	I came
<i>fahren</i>	<i>ich bin gefahren</i>	I travelled, drove
<i>bleiben</i>	<i>ich bin geblieben</i>	I stayed
<i>werden</i>	<i>ich bin geworden</i>	I became
<i>sein</i> itself	<i>ich bin gewesen</i>	I have been

Motion (*gehen*, *kommen*, *fahren*), change of state (*werden*) — and then a small set that breaks the pattern and simply has to be learned: **sein** and **bleiben**, which are the *opposite* of change, plus *gelingen* (“succeed”), *geschehen* / *passieren* (“happen”) and *begegnen* (“meet”).

No agreement — the German simplification

Here is a place where German is *easier* than French:

	French	German
he went	<i>il est allé</i>	<i>er ist gegangen</i>
she went	<i>elle est allée</i>	<i>sie ist gegangen</i>
they went	<i>ils sont allés</i>	<i>sie sind gegangen</i>

Grammar Lens

French makes the participle agree with the subject. **In the perfect, German makes it agree with nothing** — *gegangen* is *gegangen* for every person and every gender. German participles *do* still take endings when used as adjectives in front of a noun — *ein geschriebener Brief* (“a written letter”), *der angekommene Zug* (“the arrived train”), *die eingeschlafene Katze* (“the fallen-asleep cat”). It is specifically the perfect where the ending is gone. Old High German did inflect the participle here, at least variably; German lost that, along with most of its

other adjective-like endings in this position.

Why it's said this way

And note what did **not** happen: German didn't get this from Latin. The *haben*-perfect and the *sein*-perfect are native Germanic developments that grew up **alongside** the Romance ones — neighbouring languages drifting the same way through centuries of contact, the same areal spread that made the simple past retreat in French, German and Italian together. Two things to carry forward: the **split** is parallel, the **agreement** is not shared.

Practise the contrast until the choice of helper is a reflex — *ich **habe** gelernt ... ich **bin** gegangen* — and the comparison that shows off German's one economy here: *elle est allée ... sie ist gegangen*, with no ending at all.

That is where this volume pauses. In sixteen chapters you have gone from *guten Tag* to two working past tenses, and the method has not changed once: take the word apart, find the English cousin sleeping inside it, and let the family tree do the memorising for you. The next volume picks the thread back up with describing what you see.

Chapter 17

Head and Hand

17.1 Der Kopf — “the head”

Learn the first body part with its article and its characteristic final sound.

You’ll want to know: der Kopf

der Kopf — the head

It is masculine and capitalised because every German noun begins with a capital letter.

Sounds you’ll need

At the end of **Kopf**, close for *p* and release directly into *f*. English has no identical native ending, so practise it slowly:

Ko-p-f → **Kopf**

Grammar Lens: Kopf + Schmerzen

A useful phrase is:

Ich habe Kopfschmerzen. — I have a headache.

German compounds simply place nouns together: **Kopf** (head) + **Schmerzen** (pains).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Kopf originally meant a **cup or bowl**. It is related to English **cup**; both were early borrowings of Late Latin *cuppa*. A container word became slang for the skull and eventually took over the everyday job. German's older inherited head-word did not disappear completely. The next micro-lesson follows it into compounds and compares the same container metaphor in French.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “der Kopf” — release *p* into *f*
- “Ich habe Kopfschmerzen.”
- “Kopf — cup or bowl”

Twice through: “Der Kopf — masculine, capitalised.”

Before you move on

Say “the head.” (**Der Kopf**.) Give its gender. (**Masculine**.) Why the capital? (It is a **noun**.) What did *Kopf* first mean? (A **cup or bowl**.) Name the related English word. (**Cup**.) Next: find the inherited word *Haupt*.

17.2 Kopf / Haupt — two head-words

Kopf began as “cup.” German's inherited word for “head” is **Haupt**, a cousin of English *head* and Latin *caput*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

language	inherited form
Latin	<i>caput</i>
German	Haupt
English	head
The initial <i>k</i> → <i>h</i> relationship reflects Grimm's law, the same systematic Germanic sound shift seen in Latin <i>pater</i> beside English <i>father</i> . The later	

consonants have their own history; use the initial pair as the clear signal.

Haupt survives in compounds and formal vocabulary:

- **Hauptstadt** — capital, literally “head city”;
- **Hauptbahnhof** — main station;
- **Hauptsache** — main thing.

Why it’s said this way

language	everyday word	older picture
German	Kopf	<i>cuppa</i> , cup
French	<i>tête</i>	<i>testa</i> , pot

Both languages independently promoted a vessel-word to “head,” while keeping the older head-root in words for chiefs, capitals, or main things. The vocabulary sources are both Latin loans, but the **metaphor** was applied separately: heads look like bowls in many languages.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Kopf — everyday cup-word”
- “Haupt — inherited head-word”
- “Hauptstadt, Hauptbahnhof”

Twice through: “Kopf took the job; Haupt stayed in compounds.”

Before you move on

Which word is everyday “head”? (**Kopf**.) Which inherited word survives in compounds? (**Haupt**.) Name two compounds. (**Hauptstadt**, **Hauptbahnhof**.) What parallel metaphor did French use? (**Tête**, originally a pot.) Next: the hand.

17.3 die Hand — “the hand”

After the tangle of *Kopf* and *Haupt*, here is the easiest word in the chapter — and a useful lesson about when languages **don’t** match.

You’ll want to know: die Hand

die Hand — the hand. **Feminine**, and spelled exactly like English.

Sounds you’ll need

One pronunciation note: the final **d** is said as a **t**. German devoices a consonant at the end of a word, so *Hand* **ends** like English *hunt* — but with the open *ah* of *Tag*, not *hunt*’s vowel. Add an ending and the *d* comes back: *die Hände* (“the hands”).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Hand is Germanic **handuz*, and English inherited it directly. Same word, same meaning, two thousand years apart. German and English are close relatives, and body parts are where you feel it most:

German	English
Hand	hand
Arm	arm
Finger	finger
Fuß	foot
Herz	heart

Why it’s said this way

Now the interesting part. Every Romance language in this course builds “hand” on Latin *manus*:

French	<i>la main</i>
Italian	<i>la mano</i>
Portuguese	<i>a mão</i>
Spanish	<i>la mano</i>

And Germanic — German, English — has **handuz*, which is **not re-**

lated to *manus* at all. The two families simply have different words here.

That is worth noticing, because this course keeps finding connections, and it can start to feel as though everything must connect. It doesn't. Indo-European languages share a great deal, and then diverge, and "hand" is one of the places where they diverged early and completely. The Latin word did reach German — but only as **borrowed vocabulary**: *Manuskript*, *Maniküre*, *manuell*. Learned imports, sitting beside the native word without displacing it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “die Hand” — final **d** said as **t**
- the plural, and hear the *d* return — “die Hände”
- the Germanic set — “Hand, Arm, Finger, Fuß, Herz”
- the gap — “*main*, *mano*, *mão* ... but **Hand**”

Before you move on

Say “the hand.” (*Die Hand* — **feminine**.) How is the final **d** pronounced, and why? (As a **t** — German **devoices** final consonants; the *d* returns in *Hände*.) Is *Hand* related to French *main*? (**No** — Germanic **handuz* against Latin *manus*; the families differ here.) How did *manus* reach German anyway? (As **borrowed** learned words — *Manuskript*, *manuell*.) Next: the rest of the body.

Chapter 18

Yes and No

18.1 ja — yes

The easiest German word to say, and one English almost shares.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ja = **yes**. Said *yah* — remember German **j** is pronounced like English **y**, never the English “j.”

It’s an ancient **Germanic** word, and English kept the very same root in the one word that still clearly shows it:

- **yea** — the old, formal “yes” (*the yeas and the nays* in a vote) — this is *ja*’s direct cousin, same Proto-Germanic root.
- **aye** — the sailor’s and parliament’s “yes” (*Aye, aye, captain*) — *sounds* like a cousin, but its origin is actually **uncertain**; it may come from a different word entirely, so don’t bank on it.

So German *ja* and English *yea* are the same little word, split between two cousin languages. (English’s everyday *yes* is a compound of that same *yea* with an old “be it so.”)

Grammar Lens: A German habit to file away

German also has a **third** answer-word, **doch**, for one special job: contradicting a **negative** — exactly like French *si*. If someone says something *isn’t* so and you insist it *is*, you say **doch**, not *ja*:

Du kommst nicht? (“You’re not coming?”) — **Doch!** (“Yes I am!”)

You'll drill *doch* on its own later; for now, keep *ja* for a plain yes and know *doch* is waiting for the contradictions.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ja” — *yah*, the j like English y
- the English cousin — “yea... ja” (and maybe *aye*)
- the contradiction preview — “Du kommst nicht? — Doch!”

Before you move on

How do you say yes in German? (**ja**, *yah*.) How is the **j** pronounced? (Like English **y**.) Which English word is *ja*'s firm direct cousin? (**yea** — *aye* only looks like one; its origin is uncertain.) What German word answers *yes* specifically to contradict a **negative**? (**doch**.)

18.2 nein — no

German's “no” is a tiny sentence with a number hidden inside it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nein = **no**. Said to rhyme with English *nine* (the **ei** in German is always *eye*).

Take it apart and it's two words fused: **ni** + **ein** — literally “**not one**.” English did the *exact same trick*: **ne** + **one** → **none**. So German *nein* and English *none* are the same idea — “not a single one” — hardened into a bare “no.”

Why it's said this way

That **n-** at the front is not a coincidence. A single ancient sound — linguists write it **PIE *ne** — is the negator behind an astonishing sweep of languages you're learning:

from PIE *ne

Latin	<i>nōn</i> → Spanish no , French non
German	nein (<i>ni</i> -ein)
Hindi	nahīm (from <i>na</i>)
English	no, not, none

Learn *nein* and you’ve really met the same “n-of-no” that will greet you again in Hindi, and that you already met in Spanish and French. One negative, half the world.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nein” — rhymes with *nine*
- taken apart — “ni + ein = not one”, like English *none*
- the family — “nōn... non... nein... nahīm” — all the PIE *ne*

Before you move on

How do you say no in German? (**nein**, rhymes with *nine*.) What two words is it fused from, and what do they mean? (**ni** + **ein** — “not one.”) Which English word is built the same way? (**none** = *ne* + *one*.) What ancient sound links German *nein*, Latin *nōn* and Hindi *nahīm*? (PIE ***ne**, the negator.)

Chapter 19

Please

19.1 **bitte** — turn a known word into a polite request

You already use **bitte** after **danke** to mean “you’re welcome.”
Now give that same small word its other everyday job: **please**.

You’ll want to know: A complete small request

Wasser, bitte. — Water, please.

Nothing here is new except the job **bitte** is doing. You learned **Wasser** in Chapter 11. Put **bitte** after the thing you want and the two known words become a complete, polite small request. The comma marks the little pause you will naturally hear before **bitte**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Bitte is the request form of **bitten**, “to ask, request, pray.” Its English cousins are **bid**—as in “I bid you welcome”—and **bead**, whose oldest meaning was a prayer. A prayer bead was first the object used to count those requests.

So when you add **bitte**, the word itself is already doing the asking.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Wasser.” — water
- “Wasser, bitte.” — water, please

- the root family — “bitten, bitte, bid, bead”

Before you move on

Ask politely for water. (**Wasser, bitte.**) What older lesson supplied both words? (**Bitte** came from the courtesy loop; **Wasser** came from the food chapter.) Which verb is **bitte** built from? (**Bitten**, “to ask or request.”) Name its two English cousins. (**Bid** and **bead.**)

Chapter 20

Sorry

20.1 Entschuldigung — “sorry” / “excuse me”

You already know **bitte** does triple duty for “please,” “you’re welcome,” and “here you go.” German’s word for **sorry** is just as hard-working: **Entschuldigung** covers both “**excuse me**” and “**I’m sorry**.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **ent-** = a “removal / undoing” prefix — the same shape as in **entdecken** (“un-cover” → discover) or **entfernen** (“un-distance” → remove).
- **Schuld** = “**guilt, fault, blame**” (also, separately, “debt” — a *Schuld* can be money owed or wrong done).
- **-igung** = a noun-forming suffix, roughly “-ing/-ation.”

So **Entschuldigung** is literally “**an un-guiling**” — the act of removing blame. Saying it hands the guilt back: *I release you from any fault* (when getting someone’s attention or brushing past) or *I ask you to release me from mine* (when apologizing).

Schuld has a striking cousin: it traces to the same ancient Germanic root as English **shall** and **should** — a verb that originally meant “**to owe**.” *Schuld* (what is owed, guilt) and *shall* (what one is obliged to do) are, at root, the same idea of an obligation outstanding.

Why it's said this way

For **deeper regret** — real sorrow, not a bump in the hallway — German often reaches for **es tut mir leid**, literally “**it does to-me sorrow**”:

- **es** = “it,” **tut** = “does” (from **tun**, “to do”), **mir** = “to me,”
Leid = “sorrow, suffering” (a cousin of English **loath**, both from a root meaning “hateful, painful”).

Use **Entschuldigung** for the everyday sorry/excuse-me (stepping on a foot, interrupting), and **es tut mir leid** when you mean it more — condolences, a real regret. The two overlap; native speakers move between them by feel.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Schuld” — guilt/fault — then “Entschuldigung,” sorry / excuse me
- the deeper phrase — “es tut mir leid,” it pains me / I’m so sorry

Before you move on

What does **Entschuldigung** literally mean, piece by piece? (“**Un-guiling**” — *ent-* “away” + *Schuld* “guilt/fault.”) What English word shares Schuld’s ancient root? (**Shall/should** — both from a root meaning “to owe.”) What’s the deeper phrase for real regret? (**Es tut mir leid**, “it does to me sorrow.”)

Chapter 21

Weather

21.1 das Wetter, es regnet — German’s own native words, English’s own cousins

Every Romance language you’ve met so far shares the exact same Latin word for “weather” (*tempus*). German breaks completely from that family — with a word that’s actually a much closer cousin of English.

The two words: das Wetter and weather

das Wetter = “**weather**” — from Proto-Germanic *wedraq* — the **exact same word** as English **weather** itself (both descend from the same Germanic ancestor, not one borrowed from the other). Unlike Spanish’s *tiempo*, French’s *temps*, or Latin’s own *tempus*-family, German’s weather word has **no connection to Latin at all** — it’s a native Germanic inheritance, cousin to English rather than to Romance.

Grammar Lens: Es ist heiß / Es ist kalt

Es ist heiß. — “It’s hot.” — literally “it **is** hot.” **Es ist kalt.** — “It’s cold.” — literally “it **is** cold.”

German uses **sein** (“to be”) here — matching the same “**be**” pattern you already met in German’s own AGE lesson (*ich bin zwanzig*), not the Romance “make” periphrasis (*hacer/faire*).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Es regnet. — “It’s raining.” — from **regnen** ← Proto-Germanic *regnōnq* — the **same root** as English **rain**. Just like *Wetter*/ “weather,” this is a genuine Germanic cousin-pair, not a shared Latin borrowing the way Spanish’s *llueve* and French’s *pleut* are.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Wetter” — weather, the same word as English “weather”
- “Es ist heiß. Es ist kalt.” — it’s hot/cold
- “Es regnet” — it’s raining, same root as English “rain”

Before you move on

Does **Wetter** come from Latin, like the Romance languages’ weather words? (**No** — it’s native Germanic, the same word as English “weather.”) What verb does German use for “it’s hot/cold” — *sein* (“be”) or a *hacer*-style “make”? (**Sein**, “to be” — matching German’s own AGE pattern.) What English word is **regnet** related to? (**Rain** — same Proto-Germanic root, *regnōnq*.)

Chapter 22

Dog and Cat

22.1 Hund, Katze — one native word, one surprising loan

Here’s a real surprise to end this comparison on: German’s word for “dog” is native and expected — but its word for “cat” secretly isn’t native at all.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Hund (“dog”) is native Germanic, from **Proto-Indo-European** **kwon-* — and it has a direct cousin sitting inside English itself: **hound**. Old English **hund** was the ordinary, everyday word for “dog” for centuries — until, for reasons nobody fully understands, **dog** (Old English *docga*) pushed it out by the 16th century, leaving *hound* to narrow down to just hunting dogs. English’s *dog* is, honestly, its **own** unexplained mystery word, with no confirmed cognates in any other language — the exact same *shape* of story as Spanish’s *perro* displacing *can*, just in a completely different language family.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Here’s the twist: **Katze** (“cat”) looks like it should be native Germanic too, sitting right next to native *Hund* — but it isn’t. **Katze** descends from Proto-Germanic **kattuz*, which is itself a borrowing of the **same Late Latin cattus** you already met with French’s *chat* and Spanish’s *gato* — most likely ultimately **Afro-Asiatic**, traveling out of Egypt along Roman trade routes. Every Germanic language shows this **same** borrowing (Dutch *kat*, Swedish *katt*, Icelandic *köttur*) — so unlike “dog”

words, which go their own separate ways in nearly every language, “cat” words are remarkably **widespread** across both Germanic and Romance, because the word traveled **with the animal itself**. Be honest that this isn’t a universal rule, though: **Romanian** (*pisică*) and much of **South Slavic** (Serbian/Croatian *mačka*) built their own onomatopoeic cat-words instead, imitating the sound of a cat’s call rather than inheriting *cattus* — so the spread is wide, but not without real exceptions.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Hund” — dog, native Germanic, cousin of English “hound”
- the parallel — English replaced “hound” with the still-mysterious “dog,” the same shape as Spanish’s *perro*/can
- “Katze” — cat, surprisingly a Latin loanword, not native at all

Before you move on

Is **Hund** native Germanic, and what’s its English cousin? (**Yes** — cousin of English **hound**.) What word did English replace *hound* with, and is that word’s origin known? (**Dog** — genuinely **unexplained**, no confirmed cognates anywhere.) Is **Katze** native Germanic? (**No** — surprisingly, it’s the same borrowed Late Latin *cattus* behind French’s *chat* and Spanish’s *gato*.)

Chapter 23

Green and Yellow

23.1 grün, gelb — English’s own cousin, and a secret cousin of French

German’s green word is a direct cousin of English’s own word. Its yellow word has a cousin too — but a much more surprising one, sitting inside French.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

grün (“green”) is native Germanic, from Proto-Germanic **grōniz*, ultimately from **Proto-Indo-European** **ǵʰreh₁-*, “to grow, to become green” — the **exact same root** as English’s own **green**. Be careful, though: this is a **completely different** root from Latin’s **viridis** (source of Spanish’s *verde*, French’s *vert*), which traces to its own, separate “to grow/flourish” root, **weis-*. Two unrelated language families each independently built a “green” word out of a verb meaning “to grow” — a real coincidence of logic, not a shared word.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gelb (“yellow”) is native too, from Proto-Germanic **gelwaz* — and the same word as English’s **yellow**. Trace it back far enough, to **Proto-Indo-European** **ghel-* (“to shine,” with derivatives covering yellow, green, and gold), and it is usually said to land on the **same ancient root** behind Latin’s **galbus/galbinus** — the source of **French’s** **jaune**. Honesty check, though: that particular link is **less secure** than it looks — some modern Latin scholarship treats *galbus*’s origin as genuinely unknown rather than confirming the **ghel-* connection. So *gelb* and

jaune are **probably** PIE-level cousins, despite belonging to completely different language families and reaching German and French by entirely separate paths — just don’t treat the link as airtight.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “grün” — green, direct cousin of English’s own “green”
- “gelb” — yellow, probable hidden cousin of French’s *jaune*
- the contrast — grün’s root is unrelated to Latin’s *viridis*, but gelb’s root is **PROBABLY** shared with French’s *jaune*

Before you move on

Is **grün** related to Latin’s *viridis*? (**No** — a completely different root, though both independently mean “grow” → “green”; *grün* IS a direct cousin of English’s own “green.”) What French word is **gelb**’s probable PIE cousin, and how solid is that link? (**Jaune** — both usually traced to PIE **ghel-*, “to shine,” though modern Latin scholarship treats *galbus*’s origin as genuinely unknown, so the connection is probable, not certain.)

Chapter 24

Verbs of the Mind

24.1 denken — the verb that was inside *danke* all along

In Chapter 3 you learned that **danke** is built on a verb meaning “to think.” Here is that verb, with its own forms at last.

Sounds you’ll need

- vowel-**e-german** — a short, open *e*.
- **ng-cluster** — *n* before *k* is the *ng* of *sing*: **denken** = *DENG-ken*.

You’ll want to know: denken

denken means “**to think**,” with the same audible endings you drilled on *wohnen*, *machen* and *lernen*:

- **ich denke** — I think · **wir denken** — we think
- **du denkst** — you think · **ihr denkt** — you all think
- **er denkt** — he thinks · **sie denken** — they think

Ich denke, also bin ich. — “I think, therefore I am.”

It also carries Chapter 21 straight into a new sentence:

Ich denke, es ist kalt. — “I think it is cold.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

denken is Proto-Germanic **þankijanq.* English **think** is that same inherited word — a loan in neither direction.

One consonant separates them, and you have been taught how to read it. With **Haupt** beside *head* you met **Grimm’s law**, which turned Proto-Indo-European **k* into Germanic *h*. The same law turned PIE **t* into Germanic **þ*, the *th* sound. English kept it and spells it **th**: *think*. German later softened it to **d**.

Germanic **þankō* meant both “a thought” and “gratitude” — hence German **Dank** and **Gedanke**, and English **thank** beside **think**. To thank was to hold someone in thought. German also kept a sibling verb, **dünken**, “to seem”; English had that one too and let it collapse into *think*.

Grammar Lens: also does not mean “also”

In *Ich denke, also bin ich*, the word **also** means “**therefore**.” English *also* is *eall swā*, “all so,” meaning *likewise*; German *also* is *al + so*, meaning *thus*. Same bricks, different building. A German saying **also** is drawing a conclusion, not adding to a list.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich denke, du denkst, er denkt”
- “wir denken, ihr denkt, sie denken”
- “Ich denke, also bin ich.”
- “Ich denke, es ist kalt. Das Wetter ist gut.”
- the family — “denken, danke, Dank, Gedanke”
- the shift — PIE *t*, Germanic *th*, German *d*: think, denken

Before you move on

Which chapter-3 word is built on **denken**? (**Danke**.) Is English *think* a borrowing? (**No** — both inherited **þankijanq.*) Which law turned PIE **t* into the Germanic *th* German made a *d*? (**Grimm’s law**, as

in *Haupt* and *head*.) What does German **also** mean? (**Therefore**.)

24.2 verstehen — standing around a thing until you see it

You can say **ich denke**. Thinking happens in the **Kopf**; this is the verb for when it lands — and English built its own word from the same picture, separately.

Sounds you'll need

- **v-as-f** — German **v** is said *f*, so *ver-* is *fair-*.
- **h-silent-lengthening** — the **h** is silent; it marks the vowel before it as long. **verstehen** = *fair-SHTAY-en*.

You'll want to know: verstehen

verstehen means “**to understand**,” with the ordinary endings:

- **ich verstehe** · **wir verstehen**
- **du verstehst** · **ihr versteht**
- **er versteht** · **sie verstehen**

Ich verstehe. — said on its own, constantly. **Ich verstehe Deutsch.** — “I understand German.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Break it in two: **ver-** plus **stehen**, “to stand.” *Stehen* is English **stand**, the same inherited word, Proto-Germanic **standanq*. The prefix **ver-** is old and worn, and here it carries its ancient sense “around, about.” So *verstehen* is literally “**to stand around**” a thing.

Now English. **Understand** is *under* + *stand* — and that *under* is not “underneath.” The usual explanation is that Old English *under* also carried the sense “among, between,” a cousin of Latin *inter*; so *understand* is “to stand **among**” a thing. That reading is standard but not certain, and no honest account will claim otherwise.

Either way the important fact holds: **each language welded a prefix**

onto its own inherited verb “to stand” and got a word for **comprehension**. Neither borrowed the compound. Chapter 23 showed the same move with **grün**: Germanic and Latin each built “green” from a verb for “grow,” independently. This is that coincidence one family closer in.

The verb underneath is one of the family’s biggest roots, PIE **steh₂-*: German **der Verstand** (“reason”), English **stand, stead, stall**, and — from Latin’s *stāre* — **state, station, stable, constant**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich verstehe, du verstehst, er versteht”
- “Ich verstehe Deutsch.”
- both verbs — “Ich denke. Ich verstehe.”
- the pieces — “ver- + stehen” beside “under + stand”
- the parallel — like *grün* beside *viridis*, built, not shared
- where it happens — “der Kopf” — and what stands in it, “der Verstand”

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of **verstehen**? (**Ver-** + **stehen**.) Which English verb is *stehen*? (**Stand**.) Did English borrow *understand* from German? (**No** — each built its own compound.) How solid is the “under = among” account? (**Standard, but not certain**.) Say “I think” and “I understand.” (*Ich denke. Ich verstehe*.)

24.3 lesen — gathering, and the first verb that changes its vowel

Every German verb so far has kept its vowel in every form. This one does not — and its older meaning is **gathering**.

Sounds you'll need

- long-e — a long *e*, English *ay* without the glide.
- s-voiced — a single *s* between vowels buzzes like *z*: *LAY-zen*.

You'll want to know: lesen

lesen means “to read.”

- **ich lese** — I read · **wir lesen** — we read
- **du liest** — you read · **ihr lest** — you all read
- **er liest** — he reads · **sie lesen** — they read

Ich lese Deutsch. — “I read German.”

Grammar Lens: the vowel that breaks in the middle

Four forms keep the *e* of *lesen*. Two swap it for a long *ie*: *du liest*, *er liest*.

That is the mark of a **strong verb**: the vowel changes inside the word, in exactly two present-tense forms — **du** and **er/sie/es**. Nothing else moves; the endings stay the familiar *-e* / *-st* / *-t*. It is a rule about a whole class of verbs, not about *lesen*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

lesen is Proto-Germanic **lesaną*, “to gather.” That sense still lives in **die Weinlese**, the grape harvest — the *wine-gathering*, built on the **Wein** of Chapter 11. Reading came second: you pick the letters up, one after another.

Now the trap. Latin **legere** also meant “to gather,” also came to mean “to read,” and stands behind **legible**, **lecture**, **lesson** and **collect**. It looks like one shared word. It probably is **not**: the sounds do not correspond as they should, and the standard account ties *lesen* to a separate root, whose clearest cousin is Lithuanian *lèsti*, “to peck up grain.” Treat it as you treated **grün** beside *viridis*.

English **read** is a third story: Old English *rædan*, “to advise,” which is German **raten** and **das Rätsel** (“riddle”). *Lesen* and *read* are no relation.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich lese, du liest, er liest” — hear the vowel break
- “wir lesen, ihr lest, sie lesen” — and back
- “Ich lese Deutsch. Ich verstehe Deutsch.”
- the old meaning — “die Weinlese”
- the three so far — “denken, verstehen, lesen”
- why *lesen* is not *legere* — the reason *grün* is not *viridis*

Before you move on

Which two forms of a strong verb break their vowel, and what are they here? (**Du** and **er/sie/es** — ***du liest, er liest.***) What did *lesen* mean first? (**To gather** — *die Weinlese.*) Is it Latin *legere*? (**Probably not** — the sounds do not correspond.) And English *read*? (**No relation** — it meant “to advise,” and is German *raten.*)

24.4 schreiben — the one borrowed verb

Three verbs in, all three English’s own blood relatives. The fourth breaks the run: **German borrowed it; English did not.**

Sounds you’ll need

- sch-sh — **sch** is one sound, English *sh*.
- diphthong-ei — **ei** is said *eye*: **schreiben** = *SHRY-ben*.

You’ll want to know: schreiben

schreiben means “to write.”

- **ich schreibe** — I write · **wir schreiben** — we write
- **du schreibst** — you write · **ihr schreibt** — you all write

- **er schreibt** — he writes · **sie schreiben** — they write

Ich schreibe Deutsch. · **Die Hand schreibt.**

Grammar Lens: strong, but not here

Lesen taught you to watch **du** and **er**. Here: *du schreibst, er schreibt* — **the vowel does not move**. *Schreiben* is strong (its past is *schrieb*), but its present is smooth. So the rule is exact: a strong verb *may* break its vowel there. Hold the pair: *du liest*, but *du schreibst*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

schreiben is Latin *scr̄ibere*, and before that “**to scratch**.” German took it in with the writing itself, and early: the loan passed through German sound changes — *sc-* became *sch-* — and joined the native strong verbs, its past becoming *schrieb*. A late loan would have done neither.

English refused it. **Write** is Old English *writan*, also “**to scratch**,” because runes were cut; German **reißen** and **ritzen** are its relatives. Two languages, two writing-words, both meaning *scratch*. Latin’s verb reached English anyway: **scribe**, **script**, **describe**, **transcript**.

And one closes a circle from Chapter 17. German **Hand** has **no Latin cousin** — Latin says *manus* — yet *manus* reached German as a loan: **Manuskript**. *Manu-* is *manus*, the hand; *-skript* is *scr̄iptum*, this verb. A **Manuskript** is written *by hand*: the Latin hand-word German never inherited, bolted to the Latin writing-verb it did.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Die Hand schreibt. Ich schreibe Deutsch.”
- the four “I” forms — “ich denke, ich verstehe, ich lese, ich schreibe”
- the four “he” forms — “er denkt, er versteht, er liest, er schreibt” — only *liest* broke
- three inherited, one borrowed — “denken/think, verstehen/stand, lesen/gather”, then “schreiben/scr̄ibere”
- denken’s *d* — PIE *t*, Germanic *th*: Grimm’s law

- “Ich denke, also bin ich.” — and what *also* does
- *Manuskript* — *manus* plus *scriptum*

Before you move on

Say all four “I” forms. (*Ich denke, ich verstehe, ich lese, ich schreibe*.) Which is the loan? (*Schreiben*, from *scribere*, “to scratch” — as English *write* also meant.) Which “he” form breaks its vowel? (Only *liest*.) Which half of *Manuskript* did German never inherit? (*Manus*, its own **Hand**.) And German *also*? (**Therefore**.)

Chapter 25

Taking, Asking, Helping, Liking

25.1 nehmen — the verb English threw away

Four verbs about doing rather than thinking. **Schreiben** was a Latin word German took and English refused; this one is the reverse — a Germanic word English threw away and German kept.

Sounds you'll need

- long-e — a long *e*: **nehmen** = *NAY-men*.
- h-silent-lengthening — the **h** is silent, marking the long vowel.

You'll want to know: nehmen

nehmen means “to take.” It is what a **Hand** does.

- **ich nehme** — I take · **wir nehmen** — we take
- **du nimmst** — you take · **ihr nehmt** — you all take
- **er nimmt** — he takes · **sie nehmen** — they take

Grammar Lens: the rule again, and harder

You know where to look: **du** and **er**. Long *e* becomes short **i** — *du nimmst*, *er nimmt* — while *wir*, *ihr* and *sie* keep the *e*. This goes further than *lesen* did: once the vowel shortens the silent *h* has no job, so it drops and the **m** doubles: *nehmen* but *nimmt*. Say

them back to back — *NAY-men*, *NIMT*.

Three shapes now: *du liest* breaks its vowel; *du nimmst* breaks it and respells the word; *du schreibst* does not break at all.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nehmen is Proto-Germanic **nemaną*, “to take.” English had it — Old English *niman* — and then **lost it**, because Norse settlers brought *taka* and English took **take** instead.

A lost word leaves fossils, and English carries two. **Numb** is the old past participle of *nim*: a hand *taken* by the cold. **Nimble** is “quick to take hold.”

Beyond Germanic the root **nem-* meant “to assign, to allot,” and Greek’s version is unexpectedly familiar: *némein*, “to distribute,” gives **nomad**, **economy** and **nemesis**.

Why it’s said this way

German **bekommen** means “**to receive, to get**” — not “to become.” Both are built from the same prefix and the same verb of motion, and then the meanings walked off in opposite directions. A German saying **Ich bekomme...** in a café is being served, not transformed. **Recognise** *bekommen*; **say** *nehmen*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich nehme, du nimmst, er nimmt” — *NAY-me*, *NIMST*, *NIMT*
- “wir nehmen, ihr nehmt, sie nehmen” — the long *e* is back
- “Die Hand nimmt. Die Hand schreibt.”
- the three shapes — “du liest, du nimmst, du schreibst”
- the fossils — “nehmen, numb, nimble”
- borrowed against lost — “schreiben came in from Latin; niman went out”
- the trap — “bekommen is *receive*”

Before you move on

Give the *du* and *er* forms. (*Du nimmst, er nimmt* — the *h* drops, the *m* doubles.) Which verb replaced the English cousin of *nehmen*? (**Take**, from Norse.) Name the two fossils it left. (**Numb** and **nimble**.) What does **bekommen** mean? (**To receive**.) And say “the hand takes.” (*Die Hand nimmt*.)

25.2 fragen — asking, and the three answers German gives back

After two vowel-breaking verbs, a rest: this one keeps its vowel everywhere. And you already own its answers — all **three** of them.

Sounds you'll need

- vowel-a-german — a pure open *ah*: **fragen** = *FRAH-gen*.
- r-uvular-german — the soft guttural *r* you first met in *lernen*.

You'll want to know: fragen

fragen means “to ask.”

- **ich frage · wir fragen**
- **du fragst · ihr fragt**
- **er fragt · sie fragen**

The noun sits beside it: **die Frage**, “the question.”

Grammar Lens: the vowel that stays

Check the two forms that break in a strong verb. *Du fragst. Er fragt.* The *a* has not moved.

fragen is a **weak** verb — the ordinary kind, built like *lernen* and *machen*: endings only, stem untouched. That matters, because after *lesen* and *nehmen* it is easy to start breaking vowels everywhere. Most German verbs are weak; the strong ones are a closed club, learned one at a time. Hold the pair: **du nimmst**, but **du fragst**.

Why it's said this way

An asked question wants an answer, and you have the whole German set already. English has two. German has **three**:

- **ja** — yes.
- **nein** — no.
- **doch** — the one English has no word for: *yes, against what you just said*. It exists to contradict a negative.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

fragen goes back to Proto-Indo-European **prek-*, “to ask.” Germanic turned that opening *p* into an *f* — the Grimm’s-law step that puts *father* beside Latin *pater*.

English once had the cousin, Old English *frignan*, and dropped it, just as it dropped the cousin of *nehmen*. The word it uses instead, **ask**, is a different Germanic word and no relation.

So English gets the root back only the long way round. Latin *precārī*, “to beg, to pray,” is the same verb, and gives **pray**, **prayer** and **precarious** — literally “held only by asking for it.”

One caution: Latin *rogāre*, “to ask,” behind *interrogate*, looks like a candidate and is **not** related — it belongs with *rēx* and *right*, a root about straightening and ruling.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich frage, du fragst, er fragt” — the *a* never moves
- “die Frage” — the question
- the contrast — “du liest, du nimmst”, then “du fragst”
- the three answers — “ja, nein, doch”
- the Latin cousins — “pray, prayer, precarious”
- the two verbs English dropped — “nehmen, fragen”

Before you move on

Is **fragen** strong or weak, and how do you know? (**Weak** — *du fragst*, the vowel never breaks.) Name German's three answers. (**Ja**, **nein**, **doch** — the last contradicts a negative.) Is English *ask* a relative? (**No.**) Which English words carry the root instead? (**Pray**, **precarious**, through Latin *precārī*.) Say “I ask” and “I take.” (**Ich frage**. **Ich nehme**.)

25.3 helfen — one word, one sound law, two languages

Almost nothing sits between the two words: **helfen** *is* **help**. The lesson is the single sound that separates them — and it is not the law you already know.

Sounds you'll need

- **h-pronounced** — a real, breathed *h*, unlike the silent one in *nehmen*.
- **f-final** — a clean *f*: **helfen** = *HEL-fen*.

You'll want to know: **helfen**

helfen means “to help,” and it is strong, so you know where to look:

- **ich helfe** · **wir helfen**
- **du hilfst** · **ihr helft**
- **er hilft** · **sie helfen**

The *e* becomes **i** in *du* and *er*, exactly as in *nehmen* — the third verb to do it, so by now you can predict it.

One honest limit: when German names the person helped, that person's word takes a form this course has not taught. Keep to **Ich helfe** on its own.

Why it's said this way

The noun is **die Hilfe**, “help” — the same *e* to *i* change, frozen. And Chapter 19 gave you the shape for asking politely: name the thing, then say **bitte**.

Hilfe, bitte. — “Help, please.”

A whole request, from one new noun and one old word.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

helfen is Proto-Germanic **helpaną*, and English **help** is the same inherited word.

The only difference is **p** against **f**, from a different law than the one behind **Haupt**. That was **Grimm's law**, the *first* shift, PIE sounds into Germanic ones — seen again in *fragen's* *p* becoming *f*. This is the **second**, High German shift, much later, and the event that split German from English. After a vowel, Germanic **p** became German **f**: *helpan* → **helfen**; *ship* → **Schiff**; *open* → **offen**; *sharp* → **scharf**; *deep* → **tief**.

Outside Germanic, be honest: *helfen* has **no secure cousins** — a proposed link to Lithuanian *šelp̃ti* is disputed.

English keeps a fossil, though. *Helfen* is still strong — *helfen*, *half*, *geholfen* — and *help* was too: its old **holp** and **holpen** survive in old Bibles and dialect. English let the shape go within recorded memory.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich helfe, du hilfst, er hilft” — the *e* breaks to *i*
- “Hilfe, bitte.”
- the strong pair — “du nimmst, du hilfst” — then the weak “du fragst”
- the second shift five times — “helfen/help, Schiff/ship, offen/open, scharf/sharp, tief/deep”
- which law was which — Grimm's law gave *Haupt*; the second shift gave *helfen*

Before you move on

Give the *du* and *er* forms. (*Du hilfst, er hilft.*) Which shift separates *helfen* from *help*, and is it the one behind *Haupt* and *head*? (The **second**, High German shift — **no**, *Haupt* was **Grimm's law**.) Name two more pairs from it. (**Schiff/ship, offen/open, scharf/sharp.**) Cousins outside Germanic? (**None secure.**) Ask for help politely. (*Hilfe, bitte.*)

25.4 mögen, lieben, gern — German's three ways of liking

English says “I like.” German has **three** ways, and the commonest is not a verb.

You'll want to know: mögen and lieben

mögen (“to like”, *MER-gen* — *ö* is *ay* with rounded lips) is a **third** pattern, an old verb whose *ich* and *er* forms take no ending:

- **ich mag · wir mögen**
- **du magst · ihr mögt**
- **er mag · sie mögen**

lieben (“to love”, *LEE-ben* — *ie* is a long *ee*) is weak: *ich liebe, du liebst, er liebt.*

Ich mag die Katze. · Der Hund mag Wasser. · Ich mag das Wetter. · Ich liebe Deutsch.

A masculine **der** noun changes its article after *mögen* — untaught here, so these use **die** and **das** words.

Grammar Lens: gern hangs on any verb

gern is an adverb, “gladly,” dropped in after a verb:

Ich lese gern. — “I read gladly”: I like reading. Ich schreibe gern. · Ich helfe gern.

English must rebuild the sentence, with *like* plus a verb in *-ing*; German changes nothing. So: **mögen** for a thing, **gern** for an activity, **lieben** for love.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

All three are English words you already own.

mögen is **magana*, “to have power” — English **may**. The meaning slid from being able, to being inclined, to liking; the power sense survives in **might** and **die Macht**.

lieben is **leubaz*, “dear” — English **love** exactly, with **lief** and **believe** (to *hold dear*). **gern** is **gernaz*, “eager” — English **yearn**. So *Ich lese gern* is “I read yearningly.”

What you’ve built across these two chapters

- **vowel stays:** *denken, verstehen, fragen, schreiben* (strong only in its past).
- **vowel breaks:** *du liest, du nimmst, du hilfst*.
- **third pattern:** *ich mag, du magst, er mag*.
- **the traps:** **bekommen** is “receive,” never “become”; **also** is “therefore,” never “also.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ich mag, du magst, er mag”
- “Ich mag die Katze. Der Hund mag Wasser. Ich mag das Wetter.”
- *gern* on four — “Ich lese gern. Ich schreibe gern. Ich helfe gern. Ich frage gern.”
- the breakers, then not — “du liest, du nimmst, du hilfst”, “du fragst”
- all eight “I” forms — “ich denke, ich verstehe, ich lese, ich schreibe, ich nehme, ich frage, ich helfe, ich mag”

- the roll-call — “denken/think, verstehen/stand, lesen/gather, schreiben/scribere, nehmen/numb, fragen/pray, helfen/help, mögen/may, lieben/love, gern/yearn”

Before you move on

How does German say “I like reading,” literally? (*Ich lese gern* — “I read gladly.”) Say: you like the cat; the dog likes water. (*Ich mag die Katze. Der Hund mag Wasser.*) Which three of the eight break their vowel? (*Lesen, nehmen, helfen.*) And the two traps — bekommen, also? (Receive; therefore.)

Pronunciation — a reference, not a chapter

Not to be read before starting. German spelling is largely phonetic — mostly you say what you see — so this page is short. Each lesson names the sounds its word needs and points here for more.

Vowels

- **a** = open *ah*; **o** = *oh*; **u** = *oo* (*gut* = *goot*).
- Umlauts shift the vowel forward: **ä** $\approx$ *eh*, **ü** = the front-rounded *ee* (= French *u*).

Consonants that differ

- **ch** after *a/o/u* = a guttural *loch* sound (*Nacht* = *nahkht*); softer after *e/i*.
- **z** = *ts*; **s** before a vowel = *z*; **ß** = a sharp *ss*.
- **h** at word-start *is* pronounced (unlike Spanish/French).
- **w** = English *v*; **v** = English *f*; **j** = English *y*.
- **Final devoicing**: written *-d/-g/-b* are said *-t/-k/-p* (*Abend* = *AH-bent*, *Tag* = *tahk*).

Two habits

- **Every noun is Capitalized** — *Tag*, *Nacht* — not just names.
- **Final devoicing** (above).

The High German Consonant Shift

A decoding tool rather than a rule for *saying* words: German pushed certain consonants forward, so English and German cousins differ predictably.

English	→ German	example
d	t	good → gut, day → Tag
t	s / ss / z	water → Wasser, that → das
p	pf / f	apple → Apfel, ship → Schiff
k	ch	make → machen, book → Buch

(A *different* shift from Grimm's Law, the older PIE→Germanic change shared by both English and German — see the *Nacht* lesson.)